



Hindustan Times

US Senate clears bill for tariffs over Russian oil

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WASHINGTON: The US Senate on Friday approved by 86 votes to 11 a bill that would authorise tariffs of up to 100% on countries buying Russian oil, gas and other exports, with India named as one of five target economies by the bill's sponsors even as US allies in Europe are spared for similar purchases.

The measure — known officially as the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act 2026 — sets a headline ceiling but leaves the actual rate to be set by the office of the US Trade Representative (USTR), and carries a presidential waiver requiring certification to Congress with reassessment every 180 days. The bill permits — but does not necessarily compel — the executive to act against the five named purchasers —

Levies of up to 100%

HOW BILL AFFECTS INDIA
Bill targets five buyers of Russian oil, gas and other exports; India, China, Slovakia, Hungary, Azerbaijan

BILL PASSES 86-11
The bill now goes to the House of Representatives

TARIFFS CAPPED, USTR TO TAKE FINAL CALL
Actual rate to be set by the US Trade Representative; Presidential waiver built in, with reviews every 180 days.



China, India, Slovakia, Hungary and Azerbaijan — with sponsors saying the rate should be pitched high enough to deter Chinese and Indian buying.

India has in the past, when it was slapped with a 25% additional levy that has since been removed after trade negotiations, called such moves unfair since Russian exports are

soaked up by a number of other countries. India has also stated that its energy purchases are guided by its energy security needs.

The bill now moves to the House of Representatives, where Republicans control the floor calendar and where its passage in identical form is the

continued on →11

PAK, TURKEY, SAUDI FINALISE MUTUAL DEFENCE ACCORD

RIYADH/KARACHI/ANKARA: Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan signed a joint defence agreement on Friday as the three countries sought to deepen security cooperation amid heightened military tensions and conflicts in West Asia. The agreement is intended to strengthen collective deterrence against any act of aggression and stipulates that an armed attack against any of the three would be regarded as an attack on all, they said in a joint statement. →P5

DELHI NOD TO 25% LOCAL QUOTA IN PVT VARSITIES BILL

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi cabinet on Friday approved a draft law to create a legal framework for setting up private universities in the Capital, proposing provisions that will allow "vertical campuses" suited to a land-constrained city, reserve 25% of seats for Delhi students and permit foreign higher education institutions to establish campuses, among others.

A POLITICIAN CAN'T FEAR EGGS: SC JUNKS MAHUA'S PETITION

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday refused to entertain TMC MP Mahua Moitra's plea seeking permission to join a police probe virtually, telling her that having "taken the plunge into politics", she could not fear eggs being hurled at her when the country's freedom fighters faced bullets. →P5

U.S. REGULATOR TELLS AIRLINES TO CHECK BOEING 737 MAX FOR CRACKS

WASHINGTON: The US aviation regulator has asked operators of 471 Boeing 737 Max jets to undertake checks for cracks of a component that could undermine the structural integrity of the aircraft. The affected area impacts a component that structurally reinforces the front-door frame on some 737 planes, Boeing said.

It requires an inspection of the fuselage panning, according to the airworthiness directive. The checks apply to in-service models of the new-gen Max jet including the 8, 9 and 8200 variants. →P5

Vivek Vihar fire report flags illegal flats, lapses

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NEW DELHI: A Delhi-based firm, Vardhaman Business Ventures, sold flats in the four-storey residential dwelling in east Delhi's Vivek Vihar — where a deadly blaze on May 3 killed nine people — without obtaining mandatory occupancy certificates, and carried out major structural alterations flouting sanctioned plans, a magisterial inquiry report has found.

The report — submitted by northeast district magistrate

IT ALSO SAID FIRST FIRE TENDER RAN DRY WITHIN FIVE MINUTES, FORCING PERSONNEL TO SEEK MORE VEHICLES

Ajay Kumar to the Delhi home department last month, and seen by HT — also said the Delhi Fire Service's (DFS) first tender ran dry within five minutes, forcing personnel at the site to seek additional vehicles. Addi-

continued on →11



KRACKJACK JOKE #8

WHY IS JACK'S FACE SWOLLEN UP?

SCAN TO KNOW MORE





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NUMBER THEORY

August keeps the needle moving forward for monsoon

By Abhishek Jha

An El Nino that is currently underway is expected to crimp India's June-September monsoon, which accounts for 75% of the country's annual rain. This makes rainfall trends very important in August, which is the second rainiest month of the year after July and accounts for 30% of monsoon rain. HT's analysis of the gridded rainfall data of the India Meteorological Department (IMD) shows that August rain has not disappointed in filling up the country-level rain deficit and decreasing the area seeing deficit rain in many states. However, not all of the rainfall has been ideal. Here is why.

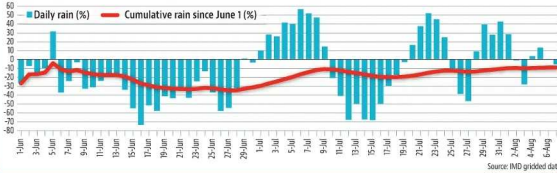


1 This is an average first week of August, but it has decreased monsoon deficit to its lowest level since June 5

According to IMD's gridded data, India has received 631 mm rain in the first week of August. This is the 61st highest or 66th lowest rain since 1901, the first year for which IMD has published gridded data, making this an average August so far. As expected, rain's departure from the 1971-2020 average, which IMD currently considers as the Long Period Average (LPA) for

tracking rain's performance, is also modest so far: 1.6%. To be sure, any surplus is welcome this monsoon season, which was reeling with a 3% deficit compared to the LPA at the end of June. The August surplus, for example, has now brought the cumulative deficit down to 9%, the lowest it has been since June 5, when the season had just started.

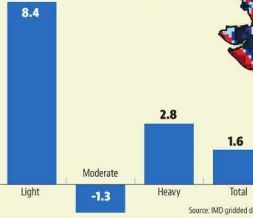
Departure of India rain from LPA in 2026



2 The surplus this week also came without a big surplus in intense rain

A surplus in all-India rainfall is possible with rain of different intensities. For example, the 1.6% surplus can be achieved by a 1.6% surplus in all intensities of rain. The same surplus can also be achieved by a large surplus in heavy rain and a large deficit in lower-intensity rain. The second scenario has been the more prominent way of a surplus in weekly rain this monsoon. There are 26 dates this monsoon when the rolling seven-day sum of rain had a surplus. 22 of those dates achieved a surplus in seven-day rain with at least a 10% surplus in rain of heavy intensity, which IMD classifies as more than 35.5 mm rain at a place in 24 hours. However, the surplus in the week ending August 7 was achieved with just a 2.8% surplus in heavy-intensity rain, the lowest for those 26 dates. In contrast, the week ending July 30 had an 11% surplus in heavy-intensity rain, but only a 0.1% surplus overall, because it had a 13% deficit in moderate-intensity rain.

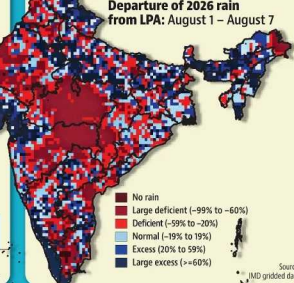
Departure in different intensities of rain in August 1-7 period (%)



3 The geographical distribution of rain was not always ideal

To be sure, India's heavy rain total can look usual irrespective of whether it falls in Goa (a place used to such rain) or Gurugram (a place not used to such rain). Some of the heavy rain this month has indeed fallen over Gurugram. This is also reflected in the skew in the geographical distribution of rain. IMD describes a surplus of 60% or more as "large excess" and that between 20% and 60% as "excess". Deficits of similar levels are described as "large deficient" and "deficient", with rain within 20% of LPA called "normal". 49% of the country is either deficient or "large deficient" in rain this month and 32% has got either excess or large excess of rain.

Clearly, the average-looking surplus this month has been distributed unevenly geographically.

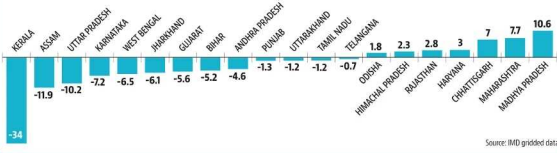


4 But the places with surplus were often places running deficit before August

Some states might welcome the geographical skew in August rain somewhat. Of the 33 states and UTs for which this calculation is possible using the gridded data, 19 saw the area under deficient and large deficient categories decrease this week compared to the cumulative status on July 31 and another four saw no change, with only 10 seeing a growth in such area.

Even among these 10, only six have seen the area under the two categories grow to more than one third of the state's area. Rajasthan, Haryana, and Madhya Pradesh are the only big states among these six states. This means that a big surplus in August often happened in places that needed it. That helped with rain accumulation, but has also led to disasters.

Change in area under deficient and large deficient categories since July 31 (% of state's total area)





Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



Veichles move through a heavily waterlogged stretch in Sector 10, Gurugram, on Friday.

PARVEEN KUMAR/HT PHOTO

Skies open, NCR sinks under familiar neglect

Aaditya Khatwani and Abhishek Jha
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NEW DELHI: Over 12 hours of torrential rainfall on Friday inundated the Capital, marooned entire neighbourhoods and submerged roads under up to four feet of water, leaving vehicles stranded, choking traffic, and laying bare the sorry state of infrastructure in Delhi that wilted in the face of three consecutive days of monsoon showers.

Safdarjung, the city's base station for weather, recorded its wettest first week of August since 2011, receiving 127 mm of rainfall during the first seven

Wettest stations in city

24-hour data ending 8:30pm on Aug 7 (in mm)

Push Vihar*	147.5	Pusa	67.5
Chhatrapur	134.5	Narayana	66
Ayanagar	91.3	Mayapuri Vihar	65
Palam	91	Ridge	52.2
Safdarjung	80.3	Lodi Road	49.3
Janakpuri	72.5	Najafgarh	39.5
Jharoda Kalan*	69.5	Jafarpur	15.5

*Data available for only 12 hours

days of the month till 8:30am on Friday. It received another 77.1 mm through the day, bringing the station's total for August till

8:30pm on Friday to 204.1 mm, which is 90% of the station's normal figure for the entire month.

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DOWNPOUR LEAVES TRAIL OF COLLAPSED HOUSES, FALLEN TREES

Delhi Fire Services (DFS) received 16 calls related to fallen trees and nine complaints of house and wall collapses across the city as heavy rainfall lashed Delhi on Friday. A woman and her two children were rescued after part of their house collapsed in Barari around 1pm. Tree-falling incidents were reported from Malviya Nagar, Saket, Sarinik Farm, East of Kailash and Mahipalpur. No casualties were reported, though heavy waterlogging disrupted traffic and inundated several areas as residents again voiced concerns over chronic civic failures. HT

MODI-SUKHBIR MEETING FANS ALLIANCE BUZZ

Smriti Kak Ramchandran and Ravinder Vasudeva
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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) president Sukhbir Singh Badal met on Friday, stoking speculation over the Akali Dal and the BJP renewing their alliance ahead of the Punjab polls. BJP leaders, however, maintained the party will contest the state elections alone. →P5

3 SUSPECTS IN NEET LEAK ACCUSED AS 'PUBLIC SERVANTS'

NEW DELHI: Three National Testing Agency (NTA) experts breached an 'obligation of secrecy' and circulated the question papers of the NEET-UG exam, said the charge sheet filed by the CBI before a Delhi court, which took cognisance of the indictment on Friday. Each faces the prospect of life-imprisonment and a ₹1 crore fine, with the agency moving to prosecute them as 'public servants'. →P2

VIJAY: TN WON'T COMPROMISE ON CAUVERY ISSUE

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister Vijay on Friday said there would be no compromise on the Cauvery issue or on fighting against the construction of Mekedatu dam in Karnataka. "Cauvery is our lifeline; it is an emotional issue for us," Vijay said in the state assembly. →P4



FCRA bill: MEA rebuffs US lawmakers' criticism

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NEW DELHI: India on Friday pushed back against criticism by American lawmakers of proposed changes to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), saying this is an internal matter and pointing out that even the US has regulations to control the flow of foreign funding.

Lawmakers from the Democratic and Republican parties in the US have criticised proposed changes to FCRA on the grounds that they could hit Christian organisations and other civil society groups by preventing access to foreign funding and lead to their assets being seized.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal

MEA SAID PROPOSED CHANGES TO FCRA ARE AN INTERNAL LEGISLATIVE ISSUE THAT CAN BE DECIDED ONLY BY INDIA'S PARLIAMENT

told a regular media briefing that the proposed changes to FCRA are an internal legislative issue that can be decided only by India's Parliament.

"We have seen the comments [critical of the proposed changes]. Legislative matters concerning India are our internal affairs, on which decisions are taken by the Parliament of our country," Jaiswal said. "I would also like to point out

that there are several nations, including the United States, which regulate the flow of foreign funds."

Several influential US lawmakers have criticised the planned changes to the law in recent days. Senator James Risch, who heads the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, described the proposed amendments as "deeply concerning".

Republican Congressman Riley Moore, in a recent social media post, claimed that the proposed amendments to

continued on →11

morestories

No direction from RS chair to Shah, says Rajju →P5
Oppn firms up strategy as FCRA bill looms →P5

India issues names for 27 Arunachal locations

Neeraj Chauhan and Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: India on Friday issued standard names for 27 places and geographical features in Arunachal Pradesh located along the Line of Actual Control (LAC), a move officials described as a riposte to China's efforts to rename dozens of locations in the Indian state in recent years.

This is the first time India has issued the names on a cartographic map. Among the places included in the list is the border village of Longju, which has been controlled by China since 1959 but is

INDIA SEEKS DETAILS OF UPSTREAM RIVER PROJECTS FROM CHINA

India and China have held talks on boundary delimitation, border management and transborder cooperation, with New Delhi emphasising the need for Beijing to share technical details on upstream projects on transborder rivers. These issues figured in the India-China Border Affairs meeting on Thursday. →P6

within the Indian claim line, they added. The move is aimed at reinforcing India's absolute sovereign and legal jurisdiction over these territories. →P6

PARL PANEL: ONLY 3 OF 6,510 KASHMIRI MIGRANT FAMILIES RETURN TO VALLEY

Neeraj Chauhan
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NEW DELHI: Only three of 6,510 Kashmiri migrant families that initially expressed willingness to return to the region have permanently settled in the Valley, a Parliamentary panel observed, asking the government to undertake a comprehensive assessment of the security, livelihood, education and social concerns that are holding them back. The J&K administration told the panel during its May visit to the UT that ₹7.50 lakh is offered for such families willing to return and permanently settle in Kashmir. →P8

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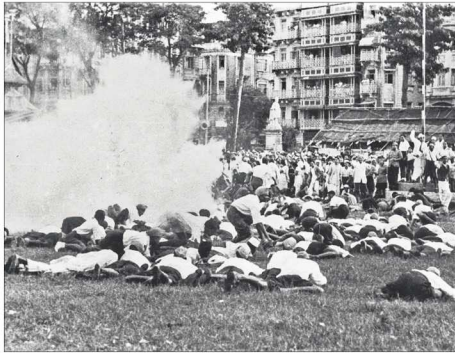
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From HT Archives

QUIT INDIA MOVEMENT, 1942



Protesters lie on the ground to avoid tear gas released by British forces. GETTY IMAGES

'Quit India' begins, British crack down with firing, arrests

Excerpts from HT's reports on the start of the movement and the British retaliation

By the summer of 1942, India's patience with its colonial masters appeared to have run its course. Lord Linlithgow had plunged India into World War II without consulting Indian political representatives or provincial ministers, triggering tremendous unrest and the en-masse resignation of Congress-led provincial governments. Successive debates by Allied Powers in East Asia had brought Japanese troops to the gates of erstwhile Burma. British promises of eventual self-governance had repeatedly dissolved into stonewalling, and the failure of Sir Stafford Cripps — who only offered dominion status after the war, expressly ruled out independence, and refused to commit to a clear timeline — had frustrated even the moderates within the Congress and convinced the leadership that further negotiation with London or the viceroy was futile.

Against this backdrop, the mood in the Congress was hardening. It was clear that drastic action was the only recourse for the nationalist movement. On August 8, 1942, the All India Congress Committee met in erstwhile Bombay and passed the Quit India resolution, demanding immediate British withdrawal from the country. That evening, Mahatma Gandhi delivered his memorable call, "Do or Die".

The British response was immediate. Within hours, the entire Congress leadership — including Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel — was arrested, and the party banned. "The police in Bombay opened fire about a dozen times in different localities on August 9, 1942. Five persons have been killed and twenty others received bullet wounds, while thirty-five more, including police, received injuries resulting from stone-throwing. The demonstrations marked the start of the 'Quit India' movement against British rule, launched after the Congress resolution adopted in Bombay on August 8," this newspaper reported on August 10, 1942.

The repression was not limited to Maharashtra but quickly spread across the country even as the second-rung leadership of the Congress — people like Ram Manohar Lohia, Jayaprakash Narayan, and Sucheta Kripalani — took over coordination and running the movement. Hundreds of strikes and hartals, walkouts and mass demonstrations crippled major cities.

"Curfew has been enforced in Bombay... In the city, 149 persons, including Mrs. Kasturba Gandhi and Mr. Pyarelal, have been arrested so far, while elsewhere in the country Dr. Rajendra Prasad and Mr. Vinoba Bhave were also taken into custody. The police had to resort to firing in Poona and Ahmedabad also. In Poona, one man was killed and another seriously injured when the police opened fire near the Congress House, and in Ahmedabad the military was called out to deal with the crowd which had gathered on Gandhi Road, where one man was killed and another injured as the result of firing," HT reported.

Yet, despite the absence of front-tier leadership, ordinary people rose to the occasion, fighting against the colonial police force and often deploying novel agitation tactics. One such instance unfolded at the famous Shivaji Park.

"Police parties and large crowds were engaged in outwitting each other for over four and a half hours at Shivaji Park on August 9, where originally it was announced that Mahatma Gandhi would address a public meeting that evening. Despite his arrest thousands of people streamed into the park, where a posse of armed police, tear gas squads and some lathi police were stationed to prevent the holding of any public meeting. The park was too big to be cleared of the crowds that repeatedly dodged the police, and frequent use of tear gas squads did not result in their complete dispersal. With buckets of water and sand the dispersed crowds re-entered the park and another clash between the tear gas squads that were thrown on them. There were a few minor clashes between the police and the crowd that kept on shouting Congress slogans, and the police, it is stated, fired a few shots, one person being removed to hospital with a bullet wound. At about 8.30 p.m. the crowd had completely left the park and the police also withdrew," HT reported.

Yet, the crackdown failed to dampen the spirit of the movement, instead inspiring a new generation of young leaders. In the absence of central leadership, resistance turned local. Students walked out of colleges. Workers struck in mills and factories. Protesters blocked railway lines, cut telegraph wires, and torched police stations and government offices.

By the time Gandhi was released one May morning in 1944, the tide had turned, both globally and nationally. The Allied Powers found their boots on the neck of the Axis Powers. And in India, the question was no longer whether the British would leave India, but when.

[MY INDIA] MANIPUR GOVT TO SC

'Tape linking Biren to strife was altered'



The Manipur government claimed in the Supreme Court on Friday that an audio tape alleging complicity of former chief minister N Biren Singh in instigating the 2023 Manipur violence was found to be "manipulated" after forensic examination by a national lab and sought dismissal of a petition on the matter with costs. The court directed that a copy of the report be shared with advocate Pratish Bhusan, appearing for the petitioner. —PTI

[WORLD] 2 GRANDPARENTS AMONG DECEASED

14-yr-old Thai student shoots dead 7 at his home and school



A 14-year-old student shot several people at a high school outside Bangkok on Friday morning, killing at least five and wounding several others, according to authorities, who said the gunman also appeared to have separately killed his two grandparents. The shooter then took his own life, officials said. Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul told reporters at the scene that "police interrogated his close friend who said the suspect had been under stress" related to his schooling. —PTI

[BUSINESS] CITING CYBER CONCERNS

OpenAI pauses some work on Astra model



OpenAI said on Friday it cannot rule out that its upcoming AI model, Astra, has "critical" cybersecurity capabilities, prompting the startup to pause some internal development and trigger safety protocols. Under OpenAI's safety guidelines, a model reaches the "critical" threshold if it can autonomously identify and exploit severe, real-world software vulnerabilities, or execute complex cyberattacks against highly secure targets without human intervention. —REUTERS

From Ckhla to Pune: How NTA questions made it put

CBI charge sheet traces paper leak network

THE INSIDERS (NTA Confidential Section)

TIER 1 These experts abused their position inside the National Testing Agency (NTA) to steal the master sets of the exam during the translation/moderation phase

A-1 MANISHA GURUNATH MANDHARE
ROLE: NTA subject expert of Botany & Zoology

MODUS OPERANDI: Assigned in the moderation and English-to-Marathi translation of Biology master sets. Marked NCERT textbooks with exact question paragraphs and dictated them to students. Conducted "special classes" at her Pune residence for 8 selected candidates.

A-2 PRAHAD VITHALRAO KULKARNI
ROLE: NTA subject expert of Chemistry

MODUS OPERANDI: Assigned to back-translation work from Marathi to English for Chemistry. Abused the lack of check-in/check-out frisking in the NTA confidential wing. Noted down all 135 Chemistry questions and answer options on small sheets of paper, sneaking them out of the secure facility. Shared leaked questions for money with students during "special classes" in Pune and Latur.

A-3 MANISHA SANJAY HALVADAR
ROLE: NTA subject expert of Physics

MODUS OPERANDI: Sourced Physics questions from translation and back-translation of Physics sets 1, 2, and 4. Memorised and noted down 60-68 questions on plain sheets once she returned to her Delhi stay. Shared handwritten notes via WhatsApp with Mandhare and another accused Tejas Shah.

TIER 2 LOCAL COACHING NETWORKS
Private educators who commercialised the leaked material directly with coaching students to enhance their institutes' academic credentials

A-4 TEJAS HARSHADKUMAR SHAH
ROLE: COO & Physics faculty, Dr. Abhang Prabhu Medical Academy (APMA), Pune

MODUS OPERANDI: Sourced 68 leaked Physics questions from Halvadar at her residence. Paid Halvadar ₹25,000 cash and a box of mangoes as a token of appreciation.

A-5 SHIVRAJ RAGHUNATH MOTEKARNKAR
ROLE: Managing partner of Renukar Career Centre (RCC) coaching institute, Latur

MODUS OPERANDI: Procured leaked Chemistry questions from Kulkarni via middleman Shirur for his candidate son. Circulated the questions to his coaching class students under the guise of "most expected" exam predictions.

TIER 3 THE ONWARD DISTRIBUTION PIPELINE (Middlemen)
The network of distributors and brokers who packaged the leak and transported it across states from Pune to Rajasthan

A-6 MANOJ BHAGWANRAO SHIRUR
ROLE: Local facilitator, Latur

MODUS OPERANDI: Served as link between Kulkarni, Motekar and Mandhare. Collected ₹5 lakh cash from candidates' parents (intended for Kulkarni).

A-7 MANISHA SANJAY WAGHMARE
ROLE: Central conspirator, Pune

MODUS OPERANDI: Served as bridge connecting candidates to Mandhare and Kulkarni. Disseminated, handled, and processed leaked material. Also managed the money trail.

A-8 DHANANJAY NIVRUTTI LOKHANDE
ROLE: Intermediate distributor (Pune-to-Nashik Link)

MODUS OPERANDI: Procured Biology and Chemistry leaks from Waghmare.

A-9 SHUBHAM MADHUKAR KHAIRNAR
ROLE: Intermediate distributor (Nashik-to-Gurgaon Link)

MODUS OPERANDI: Purchased the leaked material from Lokhande for ₹25 lakh. Arranged a safehouse at Kuber Laxmi Row House in Panach, Khairnar, where candidates memorised papers.

A-10 YASH YADAV
ROLE: Regional distributor (Gurgaon, Haryana Hub)

MODUS OPERANDI: Procured leaked Chemistry and Biology PDFs from Khairnar. Sent leaked material to Jaipur group via Telegram.

How it came apart
A Kerala MBBS student forwarded the leaked PDFs to his father's landlord in Sikar. The landlord took them to a local Chemistry teacher, Shashikant Sutar. Sutar reported the leak directly to the director general of NTA on May 7. NTA cancelled the exam five days later and handed the case to CBI.

Arrests began within days. Waghmare was picked up on May 14, Kulkarni on May 15, Mandhare on May 16, and Halvadar on May 22. Nine others named in the charge sheet are still being investigated.

Yash Yadav operated on Telegram as "hunter237" and communicated with Mangal Bhalwal under "g/Hindustan360". PDFs were posted at cyber cafes with instructions to delete the files afterwards.

Efforts to destroy the record began around the same time, per the charge sheet. Halvadar burned her master Physics notebook in her kitchen. Shah destroyed his 16-page handwritten notebook. Lokhande, who had typed typeset Waghmare's collected materials, threw his iPhone 14 Pro Max onto a highway. Khairnar said he had dropped his primary phone from a moving motorcycle. Shopkeepers along ₹25-lakh chain were forced to delete for everyone on their messaging apps.



HT reported about the Quit India movement and British retaliation in Aug 10, 1942 edition. HT ARCHIVE

PICK OF THE DAY

Park, Pune, for eight students. Class coordination went through a WhatsApp group she had created in November last year and named "Fifa world cup 2026". Her method, as the charge sheet describes it, centred on the students' own textbooks — they

that no frisking or metal-detector checks were conducted when experts entered or exited the confidential section, that CCTV feeds were not monitored live, and that only 20-25 days of footage were available when investigators sought the recordings — work in the confidential section had ended on April 7, and the case was only lodged on May 12, so none of the retained backup covered the relevant period.

The government's affidavit also said no single individual has visibility into the complete paper preparation stage, and that multiple question sets are developed independently by separate teams before moving in parallel through translation, proofreading, and finalisation. By account, from the moderation stage onwards, experts handling the papers had access to the complete final sets, with translation and back-translation, providing visibility of all four master papers simultaneously.

The 'leak' Back in Pune, each of the three ran a different operation with what they had taken. Mandhare ran her Biology classes at her residence in Gangsa Oson

Park, Pune, for eight students. Class coordination went through a WhatsApp group she had created in November last year and named "Fifa world cup 2026". Her method, as the charge sheet describes it, centred on the students' own textbooks — they

bought fresh NCERT Class XI and XII copies, on which she marked exact paragraphs containing the leaked questions and dictated the question formulations into the margins. Students transcribed these into a "fair notebook," which Mandhare corrected herself. Manisha Sanjay Waghmare, a Pune facilitator the CBI describes as running the operation out of her husband's dental clinic, later collected the physical registers from students, including two named in the charge sheet — Diya Shinde and Snehanjali Chavhan — to have them digitised.

Kulkarni's Chemistry classes ran at his home in Nanded City, Pune, from April 25-27, for nine students. He also collected the physical registers from students, including two named in the charge sheet — Diya Shinde and Snehanjali Chavhan — to have them digitised. Investigators corroborated the timing independently. MyGate, the access-control app used by his housing society, had logged the entry, exit and biometrics of visiting students and parents through April, which the CBI cross-checked against call records and phone-location data. CBI also recovered nine images of Chemistry questions and answer slips from Kulkarni's phone that matched the actual paper, alongside WhatsApp chats in which a partner asked for his address to hand him a watch in exchange for questions.

Halvadar did not run classes of her own. CBI account places her at the centre of a series of one-off transactions instead. On April 14, at her home, she dictated 68 Physics questions to Tejas Harshadkumar Shah, COO at Dr. Abhang Prabhu Medical Academy in Pune,

in exchange for ₹25,000 in cash and a box of mangoes. Shah transcribed them onto 125 pages. On April 25, he sent high-resolution WhatsApp images of the transcript to Halvadar's husband, Sanjay Sudhar Halvadar, who forwarded them to Mandhare. On April 27, Mandhare brought one Dr. Usha Adhav to Halvadar's office. Halvadar transferred the images to her office computer by USB, printed hard copies for Adhav for another ₹25,000, and — the charge sheet notes — the CCTV captured her.

Kulkarni's child also travelled outside Pune. Kulkarni dictated the leaked questions to the son of Shivraaj Motekar, who runs the Renukar Career Centre in Latur, as part of the special classes. Motekar circulated handwritten Chemistry questions to his own students through a coaching centre WhatsApp group and later posted a video on social media claiming he had "predicted the entire Chemistry paper for NEET UG 2026." Most questions in his April mock test appeared in the actual exam, CBI has said.

An expert panel constituted by Delhi University later matched the recovered leaked material against the four master sets at CBI's request. Of the 68 Physics questions Halvadar had dictated to Shah, the panel found that the two did not appear in any of the four master sets; the other 66 did. Across the wider body of material recovered from aspirants and intermediaries, the match ran as high as 85% on sets the three experts had access to.



Chief minister DK Shivakumar with Rashtriya OBC Mahasangh chief Baban Rao Taywade (left) and KPCC chief HK Hariprasad in Bengaluru on Friday.

Shivakumar calls for caste survey in state

HT Correspondent

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BENGALURU: The Congress government in Karnataka will implement its socio economic survey as part of its stated plan to expand social justice, chief minister DK Shivakumar said on Friday, while calling for a caste survey and urging OBC voters to support the party to protect their interests.

Addressing the 11th National Convention of the National OBC Mahasangh at Bengaluru's Jnana Jyothi Auditorium, Shivakumar said the government was committed to acting on the findings of the survey it had conducted.

"Our government conducted a socio economic survey, and we are committed to implementing it to deliver social justice," he said. The chief minister said the demand for a caste census was the rooted in the principle of ensuring equal opportunities and representation for different sections of society. He said Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi were committed to conducting such an exercise.

Shivakumar said Karnataka had a separate Backward Classes Department and that funds would be made available to it. He also said two thirds of the state Cabinet belonged to backward classes, Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and minorities, attributing the approach to the guidance of Rahul Gandhi and Kharge.

The convention was attended by representatives from 21 states. Shivakumar invoked Karnataka's social and political history while describing Congress as a party that had historically represented different sections of society.

"I and Hariprasad grew up in the Congress party. The Congress government is in power here. The history of Congress is the history of the country; the

THE CM SAID THE DEMAND FOR A CASTE CENSUS WAS ROOTED IN THE PRINCIPLE OF ENSURING EQUAL OPPORTUNITIES, REPRESENTATION

strength of Congress is the strength of the country. When Congress comes to power, it means people from all sections come to power."

He referred to the Constitution and to policies associated with Congress governments under Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira Gandhi, as well as the land reforms associated with Devaraj Urs.

He also cited the provision of OBC reservation during the period of Nalavadi Krishnaraja Wodeyar. Shivakumar said OBCs constituted 32% of the country's population and credited their skills and knowledge with contributing to the country's development.

"Backward classes make up 52% of the population in the country. You have built this country through your ability, art, and knowledge. You are the builders of this nation. We are aware of your demands."

He also used the convention to defend the Congress government's five guarantee schemes. Everyone laughed at a plan. The PM said implementing these schemes was impossible. We are allocating Rs 52,000 crore every year for these schemes."

EC extends SIT deadline, Buzas get one more day

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BENGALURU: The Election Commission has extended the deadline for Karnataka's electoral roll revision from August 8 to 17, giving Booth Level Officers nine additional days to complete house-to-house verification and pushing publication of the draft electoral roll to August 24 after nearly half of Bengaluru's electors were marked under the ASDDO category.

Under the revised schedule, the draft electoral roll will be published on August 24, a week later than the earlier date of August 17. The final electoral roll has also been deferred from October 19 to October 27. The draft electoral roll will be published on August 24, a week later than the earlier date of August 17. The final electoral roll has also been deferred from October 19 to October 27. The period for filing claims and objections will now run from August 24 to September 23.

B'LURU METRO SERVICES TO BE SUSPENDED ON AUG 9 FOR 2 HRS

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The BMRLC on Friday said that it will undertake essential maintenance work between 5am and 9am on August 9. The BMRLC said that it will undertake essential maintenance work between 5am and 9am on August 9. The BMRLC said that it will undertake essential maintenance work between 5am and 9am on August 9.

To facilitate the work, metro train services between Baiyappanahalli and MG Road Metro Stations will remain temporarily suspended for two hours, from 7am to 9am, it said.

According to Bangalore Metro Rail Corporation Limited, during this period, metro train services will operate as per the regular timetable on the following sections: Challahalli to MG Road, Baiyappanahalli to Whitefield (Kadugodi), Madavara to Silk Institute to Park Road, and Bommasandra. "Normal services on the entire Purple Line, including the affected section between Baiyappanahalli and MG Road, will resume from 9 am," the BMRLC said in a statement. It requested passengers to take note of the temporary service suspension and plan their travel accordingly.

UNDER REVISED SCHEDULE, BLOS CAN CONTINUE HOUSE-TO-HOUSE VISITS UNTIL AUG 17, INSTEAD OF COMPLETING THE EXERCISE BY AUGUST 8

The notice phase and disposal of claims and objections will continue until October 22, compared with October 15 under the earlier schedule. The extension comes against the backdrop of a large number of electors being placed in the ASDDO category, particularly in Bengaluru.

Across Bengaluru Urban and BBMP North, Central and South, 48,39,933 electors have been classified as Absent, Unlocated, or Absent. A further 6,56,536 have been recorded as already enrolled and 4,47,920 under other categories.

electoral units. BBMP South has the highest proportion, with 10,87,820 of its 21,44,784 electors, or 50.72%, marked ASDDO.

In BBMP Central, 8,93,731 of 18,89,919 electors, or 47.29%, fall under the category. BBMP North has 10,83,747 of 23,32,621 electors, or 46.46%, while Bengaluru Urban has 17,74,626 of 40,21,039 electors, or 44.13%, marked ASDDO.

The Bengaluru figures are substantially higher than the statewide proportion. Across Karnataka, 1,09,83,901 electors, or 19.81% of the state's 5,54,32,344 electors, have been placed in the ASDDO category.

The largest component of the statewide ASDDO figure comprises electors recorded as permanently shifted, at 66,14,354.

Another 16,34,326 have been marked deceased, while 15,90,165 have been classified as untraceable or absent. A further 6,56,536 have been recorded as already enrolled and 4,47,920 under other categories.

The Chief Electoral Officer's office said political parties had been given the ASDDO list and that the records were also available with BLOs for verification. "The list of ASDDO has been delivered to the political parties and is available with the BLOs also for verification," the office said.

The digitisation of Enumeration Forms has progressed further statewide than in Bengaluru. Karnataka's election machinery has digitised forms for 4,44,423 electors, or 80.18% of the total.

The revision has also generated applications relating to additions, deletions and corrections in the electoral roll.

The election office has received 3,83,345 Form 6 applications seeking inclusion of new voters and 3,328 Form 6A applications from NRIs.

It has also received 31,275 Form 7 applications seeking deletion and 8,25,064 Form 8 applications for correction of entries.

10K METRIC TONNE CONSTRUCTION WASTE CLEARED IN 6 DAYS, SAYS GOVT

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: As part of the "Freedom from Waste" campaign, 10,056 metric tonnes of construction and demolition waste have been cleared from 453 public locations across the city, the government said.

Greater Bengaluru Development Minister Krishna Byre Gowda on Friday directed Chief Commissioner Maheshwar Rao to issue notices to government departments that fail to undertake cleanliness and waste clearance activities.

Addressing a virtual review meeting on the "Freedom from Waste" campaign across the Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA) jurisdiction, the minister said that all government offices within Bengaluru city must mandatorily clear waste from their premises and surrounding areas. He instructed the Commissioner to issue notices to government departments that fail to carry out the required cleanliness drives.

According to a statement issued by Gowda's office, the minister noted that the campaign has been progressing successfully and gathering momentum with each passing day.

Between August 1 and August 6, 10,056 metric tonnes of Construction & Demolition (C&D) waste have been cleared from 453 public locations across the city. The directed officials to also compile details of cleanliness drives undertaken by other government departments and ensure that citizens are made aware of the progress being achieved under the campaign.

Gowda observed that it is natural for a campaign of this scale to have initial teething issues. Any issues, however minor, should be resolved promptly through better coordination among departments.

foodrun

The thindi-land Magellan's 250th taste expedition



Ajit Bhaskar

I believe this is the 250th article for this column, and I thank Hindustan Times for the chance to share my passion for the thindi, chats and snacks my city has to offer with fellow Bangaloreans. My dedicated reader may prepare for a few tearjerkers in this one. It just so happens that this column has survived a full circle today. The first piece I wrote saw me sampling the fare at Gandhi Bazaar's Namma SLN and today, I travel 2.7 kilometres at the speed of the printed word (we must imagine here a total circumnavigation of the Thindi galaxy) and touch down at Namma SLN in Jayanagar.

This iconic Muddanna style institution, which originated in the lanes of Cubbonpet over five decades ago, continues to deliver and stays true to its roots, much like you, dear readers. The place is simple (read "no seating"), a hole-in-the-wall affair that does not stock sambar nor filter coffee. I sense disappointed tourists somewhere, can you?

Either way, a couple of things that really endear this spot to me. First, their celebration of Karnataka's dill (sausage) through their idlis and dosa and second, their legendary palav. Their pudu prioritises the savoury touch and is packed with flavours alongside a subtle heat. See, the beauty is in the technique. The balance of fat and technique is such perfection, here, that even the heavily ghee-laden dosa feels light in the gut and is never cloying. The size, the roast, its all A-class.

The crowning glory with Namma SLN, of course, has always been their consistency across outlets. However, unlike Gandhi Nagar, here you will need to buy a token. It remains one of my top spots, but the dedicated seekers to the soul as much as it does to the gut. The place will, in all likelihood, remain one of my favourites.

Maybe I will revisit it for my 300th piece. The JP Nagar outlet, of course. There is so much dialogue this reminds me of. Something about the final credits not rolling just yet...

(Ajit Bhaskar, a researcher with a multinational, is famous in Bengaluru for his Thindi (food) runs. He will profile one of his preferred (or newly discovered) haunts for HT every week)



BJP plans to question Cong in house session

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: The BJP on Friday decided to adopt an aggressive strategy during the Legislative session beginning August 13 by compelling the Congress government on a host of issues, including drought, recruited Bidadi township, alleged recruitment irregularities, and the resignation of Legislative Council Chairman Basavaraj Horatti.

The legislative members of the party held a meeting in Vidhana Soudha to draw their action plan. LoP R Ashoka said that the upcoming session will be a tough challenge, where the BJP would raise the issues in both Houses and coordinate with its NDA ally JD(S) on protests against the government.

of Legislative Council Chairman Basavaraj Horatti.

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HEALTH DEPT SETS UP 30 TEAMS TO INSPECT HOTELS

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka health and family welfare department has constituted 30 special teams to conduct surprise inspections at hotels, restaurants and food outlets across Bengaluru and other major locations in the state following a rise in complaints over poor food quality, hygiene and food safety violations.

The inspection drive has been launched on the directions of minister UT Khader after the department received several complaints from members of the public, including those about medical waste, unhygienic practices and the sale of substandard food at various eateries.

Upa Lokayukta takes sou motu action against 54 officials over Hampi homestays violations

Yohan P Honadli

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BIDAR: The Karnataka Upa Lokayukta has initiated sou motu proceedings against 54 officials over alleged failures to prevent unauthorised homestays and other commercial activities in the protected area of Hampi, officials said on Friday. The decision comes after an inspection found hundreds of tourism establishments operating without the required approvals.

Justice B Veerappa took cognisance of the matter following complaints about commercial activity in Hampi's Core, Buffer and Peripheral zones. During an inspection on July 25, officials told him that at least 250 home-

THE DECISION COMES AFTER AN INSPECTION FOUND HUNDREDS OF TOURISM ESTABLISHMENTS OPERATING WITHOUT THE APPROVALS

stays were operating without mandatory permissions or licences from the Gram Panchayats or the Hampi World Heritage Area Management Authority (WHHAMA).

The proceedings cover officials associated with the Hampi authority, sub divisional officers, Tahsiladars, Taluk Pancha-

yat Executive Officers and Panchayat development officers in Hosapete and Koppal. Notices have been issued seeking explanations for the alleged failure to prevent the unauthorised activity. Justice Veerappa said the violations were particularly serious because of the restrictions governing the protected heritage area. The Supreme Court has clearly directed that no unauthorised commercial activities should be allowed in Hampi's highly protected Core Zone. However, during my inspection, I found several such illegal establishments."

He said the matter went beyond an administrative failure, describing it as a violation of a Supreme Court directive as well as India's international

commitment to UNESCO.

Under the rules governing Hampi's protected areas, unauthorised commercial construction, resorts, or homestays are not permitted in the Core and Buffer zones. Commercial and other activities in the heritage area are required to comply with the strict regulations of WHHAMA.

The Upa Lokayukta has sought records relating to permissions granted to and around Hampi. Vijayanagara deputy commissioner Kavitha S Mannikeri told HT that the Lokayukta had registered a sou motu complaint against 54 officials concerning alleged illegal homestay operations in the prohibited and buffer zones of Hampi.

HC quashes cruelty case filed by woman against mother-in-law

Ayesha Arvind

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BENGALURU: Saying that "vague and omnibus" allegations of cruelty against a spouse's relatives cannot justify their prosecution, the Karnataka High Court has quashed an FIR against a woman's mother-in-law and three in-laws. The woman, who had alleged, had denied her nutritious food, prepared ragi balls only for her son, made her wait until he had finished eating before she could have her meal, and that her husband had forced her to change shampoo, causing hair loss, among other things.

The Court observed that in light of the Supreme Court's settled legal principles, allowing the investigation to continue against the petitioners would amount to an "abuse of the legal process."

"If the facts obtaining in the case at hand or the complaint is considered on the bedrock of the allegation of cruelty declared by the Apex Court, what would

THE COURT SAID 'VAGUE AND OMNIBUS' ALLEGATIONS OF CRUELTY AGAINST A SPOUSE'S RELATIVES CANNOT JUSTIFY THEIR PROSECUTION

unmistakably emerge is, permitting further investigation even against these petitioners would become an abuse of the process of law and result in miscarriage of justice," the Court said.

The Court however, made it clear that the husband in the present case, had not approached the Court and would have to face the investigation into the allegations levelled against him.

The mother-in-law and the three relatives had moved the High Court seeking quashing of the FIR registered against them

on April 5, 2025, on a complaint filed by the woman. The couple had married in 2024, but their relationship deteriorated within a year, leading to multiple property disputes.

The in-laws approached the High Court seeking to quash the FIR, arguing that the dispute was essentially between the husband and wife and that they had been "dragged into the web of proceedings" without any basis.

Appearing in person, the complainant's woman, however, opposed the plea. She filed applications running into nearly 200 pages and took the Court through documents which, according to her, showed persistent dowry-related harassment and cruelty by her in-laws. She argued that the proceedings should continue against all the accused.

The woman claimed her husband picked fights because she visited her parents once a week, while her mother-in-law would interfere and escalate the arguments.

Arun Dev

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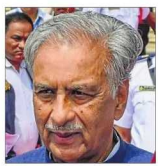
BENGALURU: The Karnataka Legislative Council chairman Basavaraj Horatti, resigned on Friday after the Congress government told him it would seek his removal through a no confidence motion if he refused to step aside, clearing the way for the ruling party to take control of the Upper House.

Horatti said the Congress government had put him under pressure to leave and had warned that it would move a no confidence motion against him if he refused. He resigned after meeting chief minister DK Shivakumar on Friday.

"I was asked to resign, so I tendered my resignation," Horatti said after the meeting. He added that he did not know what he had

been asked to step down. The chief minister's office said Horatti's resignation had been accepted and that Shivakumar would be sworn in as the 75-member archand Gehlot recommending that Horatti will remain in the chair until an alternative arrangement was made.

The chief minister said Horatti had chosen to resign in view of the current political developments and praised him for the manner in which he handled the transition. "Basavaraj Horatti has shown his magnanimity. It is commendable," Shivakumar said, adding that Horatti was one of the senior most leaders in the history of legislative councils in the country. Shivakumar said the new deputy chairperson and the person would be elected on August 14, a day after the Karnataka legislature's monsoon session begins.



Basavaraj Horatti

Shivakumar said Horatti had resigned with the consent of the Council's chairperson and deputy chairperson before thanking members and leaving the post. He said the government had agreed to respect his wishes.

Horatti's resignation came less than a week before the session begins on August 13. Congress has nominated senior law-maker Saleem Ahmed for the chairperson's post and former minister Umashree for deputy chairperson.

Congress now has a majority in the 75-member Legislative Council. There had been several rounds of discussions between Horatti and Shivakumar before the resignation, with the government seeking to avoid no confidence motion. Horatti had said on Thursday that Shivakumar told him the Congress high command had directed him to resign and that the ruling party would move a no confidence motion if he declined. "The ruling party wants me to resign. The MT spoke to me twice over the phone. On Wednesday, he called

Won't yield on Cauvery rights, Mekedatu; open to talks: Vijay

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Friday said he was prepared to face insults and even bear humiliation if necessary while travelling to neighbouring Karnataka to meet his counterpart DK Shivakumar over the Mekedatu dam issue.

Making his first statement on the Cauvery dispute in the Assembly, Vijay said his ruling Tamil Nadu government has no intention of playing politics over the issue.

"On the Cauvery issue, some members have asked for details. Cauvery is our lifeline, it is an emotional issue for us," he said, amid thumping of desks by TVK MLAs.

Vijay recalled that the Tamil Nadu Assembly had unanimously passed a resolution in June and sent it directly to Prime Minister Narendra Modi. He said that after learning that the Union minister of state for Jal Shakti had not provided full details regarding the proposed dam, the approved resolution wrote to the Prime Minister the next day, citing



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay speaks during the state Legislative Assembly session in Chennai on Friday.

ing provisions of the Cauvery Tribunal's final verdict and the Supreme Court's final verdict. The letter stated that no legal or administrative approval should be granted for construction of the Mekedatu dam.

Vijay said his government would not compromise on Tamil Nadu's rights, either on Cauvery water sharing or on stopping construction of the Mekedatu dam. "That is our clear stand," Vijay said.

Recalling a similar discussion in the Assembly in 1969, Vijay sought to know who was the water resources minister at the

legally, adding that his proposed visit to Bengaluru was an attempt to explore whether dialogue could help resolve the dispute. "When I thought about such a visit to Bengaluru and asked around, many opinions came up. But it was out of good intention, hoping that if we could get a positive sign to resolve this issue, it would be good," Vijay said.

"In today's times, even enemy nations try to resolve issues through dialogue, so I thought, why not talk to a neighbouring state and see? That is why we tried to make such an attempt." Responding to concerns that he could face an insult during such a visit, Vijay said he was prepared to bear it for the people of Tamil Nadu.

"If that happened, I was prepared to bear even that for the people of Tamil Nadu. Nevertheless, my thanks to everyone who showed affection toward us," he said. Vijay also said his government had already sanctioned relief for Kuruvai cultivation, responding to a point raised by opposition leader Udhayanidhi Stalin. "I do not understand how those who claim to be all know-

TN CM VIJAY'S WIFE SANGEETHA WITHDRAWS DIVORCE PETITION

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BENGALURU: Sangeetha, wife of Tamil Nadu chief minister C. Joseph Vijay, on Friday withdrew her divorce petition from the Family Court in Chengalpattu, near Chennai.

Family Court judge D. Sujatha allowed the withdrawal after Sangeetha appeared through video conference and confirmed that she did not wish to pursue the proceedings.

The court issued notice to Vijay's counsel, who said they had no objection. The judge then asked Sangeetha to sign the withdrawal petition and granted her liberty to file a fresh one in future, if required.

Sangeetha had filed the petition in February under Section 27(1)(a), (b) and (d) of the Special Marriage Act, alleging adultery and mental cruelty. She had also sought maintenance and granted her liberty to file a fresh one in future, if required.

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Kerala HC extends hysterectomy leave to contractual employee

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala high court has ruled that women contractual employees working on state-funded projects are entitled to leave after undergoing hysterectomy surgery, despite Rule 10(A) of the Kerala Service Rules (KSR) expressly not extending the benefit to them.

Justice Harishankar V Menon passed the order on writ petitions filed by two contractual employees working as special educators (secondary) with Samagra Shiksha Kerala since 2011 and 2007.

The petitioners underwent hysterectomy surgeries in 2022 and 2023 and were advised a month's rest each by their doctors. One of them was later advised another 15 days of rest and applied for leave again.

The State government rejected their applications, saying maternity leave benefits for contractual employees could be granted only under Rules 100 and 101 of Part I KSR and not Rule 10(A), which provides up to 45 days' leave to government employees undergoing hysterectomy.

The high court noted that the government had issued an order extending maternity leave benefits under Rules 100 and 101 to female officers appointed on contract basis.

"In my opinion, when the afore benefits are being extended as regards the claim under Rules 100 and 101 to those female officers appointed on contractual basis, there is no reason for not extending the very same benefits as regards the claim under Rule 10(A)," the judge said in his July 15 order.

The court relied on its 2018 judgment in Rakesh PV vs State of Kerala, which held that contractual employees in state-funded projects were entitled to the same maternity leave benefits as regular employees.

The court had then observed that enhanced maternity leave for women employees was "undoubtedly a piece of welfare legislation intended to give women equal opportunities in public employment."

The high court set aside the orders rejecting the two women's leave applications and directed the government to process them in accordance with the declarations made by the petitioners.

Polavaram Ph-1 on track for '27, Centre tells LS

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HYDERABAD: The Centre's financial assistance for the Polavaram major irrigation project on the Godavari river in Andhra Pradesh is limited to approved irrigation components of Phase-I, restricting water impounding to 41.15 metres, a statement tabled by Union minister of state for Jal Shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary in the Lok Sabha on Thursday said.

The statement, made in a written reply to a question by YSR Congress Party MP P V Midhun Reddy, said the Centre had approved ₹30,436.95 crore for Phase-I of the Polavaram Irrigation Project, covering water storage up to an elevation of +41.15 metres at 2023 price levels.

Of this, the balance Central grant has been capped at ₹12,157.53 crore. The Centre had already released ₹5,512.40 crore during the 2024-25 financial year and a further ₹2,816.22 crore in 2025-26 towards the execution of the Polavaram, which has been declared as a national project," Choudhary said.

He said the project was progressing as scheduled and remained on track for completion of Phase-I of the project by June 2027.

The work is right on track. The remaining critical milestones include completion of the main dam works in Gap-I and Gap-II, as well as land acquisition and rehabilitation and resettlement (R&R) activities," he said.

Clarifying the scope of Cen-

THE MINISTER ALSO MADE IT CLEAR THAT THE COST OF THE POLAVARAM POWER HOUSE WOULD HAVE TO BE BORNE ENTIRELY BY THE ANDHRA PRADESH GOVERNMENT

tral funding, Choudhary said the approved grant was confined to 41.15 metres of water storage up to +41.15 metres.

However, it also covered all civil works up to the Free Reservoir Level (FRL) of +45.72 metres, along with land acquisition and R&R works up to +41.15 metres and the Left Main Canal and Right Main Canal.

The minister also made it clear that the cost of the Polavaram Power House would have to be borne entirely by the Andhra Pradesh government as it falls outside the scope of Central assistance.

On compliance with funding conditions, the statement said the Andhra Pradesh government had been submitting the required technical documents and utilisation certificates on required time.

The Polavaram Project Authority (PPA), under the Department of Water Resources, River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation, scrutinises these documents before recommending the release of subsequent Central grant instalments.

{ OVER REMARKS AGAINST HOUSE, CM VIJAY } TN speaker rejects apology, to refer DMK MLA to House panel

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: DMK MLA Markandayan G V on Friday appealed to the Tamil Nadu Assembly to forget the remarks he made against the House and chief minister C. Joseph Vijay at a public meeting last month.

However, Assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar said he would take action as Speaker and refer the matter to the House Privileges Committee once it is constituted. The Vithaikulam MLA came under fire after he made derogatory remarks against the Assembly and the chief minister at a public meeting on July 18.

dayan had raised "excellent points" in the House on Friday, Prabhakar referred to the speech delivered at the July 18 public meeting. Calling the remarks "distressing" and "regrettable," Prabhakar said, "honourable member (Markandayan) is now speaking respectfully alongside members of the House. But the speech he delivered outside caused pain in the hearts of everyone, like you and me."

Noting that a case had already been registered and the matter was sub-judice, Prabhakar said he had two options — take disciplinary action within the House or refer the matter to the Privileges Committee.

Women's safety at risk, says SRCP, slams AP's move to scrap Disha Bill

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: The opposition YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) on Friday condemned the Andhra Pradesh government's decision to withdraw the Disha Bill, introduced by the previous Y S Jagan Mohan Reddy government to ensure speedy investigation and trial of crimes against women and children.

The Disha Bill stood as a firm shield for the protection of women and that the coalition government's decision to withdraw it would compromise women's safety," senior YSRCP leader and former home minister Taneti Vanitha told reporters at the party headquarters in Tadepalli. The state cabinet, chaired by chief minister N

Chandrababu Naidu, on Thursday decided to withdraw the Andhra Pradesh Disha Bill, 2019 (Criminal Law Amendment Bill), which was unanimously passed by the state Assembly on December 13, 2019. The Bill sought to fast-track trials in rape and sexual offence cases to a maximum of 21 days and introduce the death penalty for heinous crimes. After its passage, it was sent to the President for

AP student held over murdering giraffine

HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh Police on Friday arrested a 22-year-old engineering student for allegedly murdering his 22-year-old giraffine in Chintapalli village. Police seized the 22-year-old student, M Priyanka, on August 3. Police said their car struck her scooter twice before running over her head. Priyanka remains in critical condition in a hospital in Hyderabad, with doctors saying she is in a deep unresponsive coma.

2 students held after car runs over medic

HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh Police arrested two engineering students for allegedly driving under the influence of alcohol and running over a 24-year-old postgraduate medical student, M Priyanka, on August 3. Police said their car struck her scooter twice before running over her head. Priyanka remains in critical condition in a hospital in Hyderabad, with doctors saying she is in a deep unresponsive coma.

NIA arrests 3 in Kerala illegal explosives case

NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Friday arrested three men in connection with the seizure of a huge cache of illegal explosives in Malappuram district of Kerala.

The three were identified as Mantagudi Bhirad, Bagapudi Bheeramaiah and K. S. Gauda. The NIA said in a statement. All of the three were arrested from their native Karnataka.

Latha Rajinikanth unveils 'Makkal Medai' for citizen-led social welfare

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Noted educationist and former Tamil Nadu minister Latha Rajinikanth, Latha on Friday formally unveiled the 'Makkal Medai' initiative, a movement focused on developing social welfare projects.

In June, Latha had announced that it would be a people's movement aimed at redressing local governance and community welfare.

The primary objective is to ensure that even citizens living in remote areas have a dedicated platform to voice their concerns. On Friday, Latha unveiled the official website 'Bharata Seva' and distributed member identity cards at an event in the city.

Launched under the Bharat Seva and Dhaya Foundation (NGOs), Makkal Medai (Citizens' Platform) will focus on 7,000 ponds across various districts for de-silting and restoration.



agement and other social welfare initiatives across the State. Briefing reporters, she said the idea began 45 years ago and the Dhaya Foundation was built brick by brick. "We will continue to take forward social welfare initiatives. Only if farmers prosper, a country will prosper," she said.

She said that under the platform, volunteer efforts would be consolidated to target nearly 7,000 ponds across various districts for de-silting and restoration.

We will continue to take forward social welfare initiatives. Only if farmers prosper, a country will prosper

LATHA RAJINIKANTH

CM Vijay calls MPs meet on delimitation

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu has convened a constituency delimitation meeting of Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha members under chief minister C. Joseph Vijay to discuss the proposed delimitation exercise, minister R. Nirmal Kumar said on Friday.

Addressing the Assembly, energy, resources and law minister Kumar said the meeting would discuss the proposed constituency delimitation process by the Union government and its impact on Tamil Nadu. Kumar also asked leader of Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin whether the DMK would attend the meeting, as the party has strongly opposed the exercise.

Responding, Udhayanidhi told Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar that he had submitted an adjournment motion on the Cauvery issue and asked whether the state government would convene an all-party meeting.

"But, the minister is completely trying to divert the issue (by asking such a question)," he alleged.

When the question was raised again, Udhayanidhi said he would decide whether to attend the meeting.

Meanwhile, an official release said the meeting would be held at Kalaignar Arangam, Chepak, on August 8 at 3pm.

Invitations have been sent to all Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha members representing Tamil Nadu through the Tamil Nadu House in Delhi.

SHAH TO VISIT TN, PUDUCHERRY ON AUGUST 8-9

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NEW DELHI: Union Home Minister Amit Shah will visit Puducherry to Kerala to meet Tamil Nadu and Puducherry officials starting August 8, officials said on Friday.

During his visit, he will offer prayers at prominent temples and attend official and public events.

On Saturday, Shah will visit Tirunelveli to meet Tamil Nadu officials and attend prayers at the Sri Ramana Maharshi Ashram, followed by darshan and puja at the Arulmigu Arunachaleswarar temple, the officials said.

The minister will be in Puducherry on Sunday. He will attend the presentation of the President's Colour to Puducherry Police Ground.

Later in the day, Shah will inaugurate the 'Har Ghar Tirunelveli' at Murugan Theatre Signal, the officials said.

Former TDB chief among 3 booked in Sabarimala ghee case

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Former Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) president P Prasanth was among three people booked in a case of alleged theft of gold from Sabarimala temple, an officer said on Friday.

The FIR, filed before a Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) over alleged irregularities in procurement and supply of Milma ghee to Sabarimala temple, an officer said on Friday.

The court's order followed reports by Sabarimala Special Commissioner R Jayakrishnan and the TDB's chief vigilance and security officer Jigging alleged irregularities in the procurement of ghee from Milma, including the bypassing of standard tender procedures and auctioning of ghee at a lower price, jaggery and ghee. The vigilance officer told the high court that TDB officials abandoned an e-tender process to favour Milma. The state milk cooperative, based on a recommendation by the State Commissioner over the abandonment of the e-tendering process, had procured the ghee at a lower price. The TDB, then headed by Prasanth, subsequently approved the purchase of 1.65 lakh litres of ghee from Milma at ₹510 per litre for the 2025-26 pilgrimage season. The procurement went ahead despite objections from the Special Commissioner over the abandonment of the e-tendering process, which was also welcomed by Prasanth. 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No direction issued from NDA Chair to Shah, Rijiju clarifies

Smriti Kak Ramchandran
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NEW DELHI: The Union government on Friday said there was no direction from Rajya Sabha Chairman, CP Radhakrishnan to Union home minister Amit Shah to come to the House amid continuing discord between the ruling side and the Opposition, which persisted with its demand for a statement from the minister.



Union home minister Amit Shah on Parliament premises on Thursday.

On Friday, the opposition in the Upper House continued to push for a statement from Shah on the police excesses against students on July 20, while they were protesting against paper leaks and said the government had failed to "honour" the Chair's direction.

Leader of the Opposition Mulkaraj Kharge said, "We had made a request... for the minister to come..." over the chair, the Congress leaders could be heard saying that the government did not show "mariyada" (honour) to the Chair's comments, made a day earlier, to the government to convey the opposition's sentiment to the home minister.

But Union parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju was quick to respond that no direction was issued by the Chair and his statement was an "observation". On Thursday, Radhakrishnan asked Rijiju to "echo the sentiments of the Opposition" to Shah. "Lop is trying to disturb the house... There was no direction from the Chair. I want to say on the floor from morning to late night the home minister is in Parliament. Only those ministers reply in the house who have business listed against

their name... The Opposition will not decide which minister will speak and when... they are trying to mislead the country," Rijiju said.

He said, "No direction has been given by the chair to any minister to appear in the house and also want to say that when the opposition leaves Parliament after sloganeering the home minister continues to work late into the night, running the country. And when the home minister will give a reply, they will not have the courage to hear (what he says)." Rijiju asserted that the Opposition parties were attempting to create a narrative that the minister was absent from Parliament.

"Echo the sentiments of the Opposition" to Shah. "Lop is trying to disturb the house... There was no direction from the Chair. I want to say on the floor from morning to late night the home minister is in Parliament. Only those ministers reply in the house who have business listed against

Opp may press for statement by Shah as govt set to table FCRA bill

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: A large section of the Opposition is set to continue to press for Union home minister Amit Shah's statement on allegations of police excesses against students protesting in Jantar Mantar and stick to their demand even if the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill is introduced in Parliament next week.

The controversial bill, tabled during the budget session, might be taken up for debate and approval of the Lok Sabha next week. On Thursday, Manju chief minister Ladhuma said the debate was likely on August 12.

Congress chief whip in the Rajya Sabha, Jai Ram Ramesh, told HT, "The Opposition parties have decided to continue to demand a statement first from home minister Amit Shah on police brutality on protesting youth and students especially on July 20."

On Friday, opposition parties held a short meeting to reconfirm that they would stick to their key demand - Shah's statement. In the meeting, the leaders were also briefed about the sentiments of various stakeholders and a section of the international community for the proposed changes to FCRA.

"The Opposition parties have been very clear in our focus and commitment to run Parliament. The bill is a subject of the home minister. Come, make a statement on the floor of Parliament on the police excess on students. If he does not, he would be

responsible for the disruptions. Not this is Parliament. Not the Gujarat Gymkhana. And if they try any stunts and bring FCRA, it won't cut. First: HM statement. Then also," Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha floor leader Derek O'Brien told HT.

The bill provides for the cessation of the FCRA certificate to an organisation upon expiry, non-renewal or refusal of renewal by the government. The amendments also establish a designated authority for a comprehensive framework for vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contribution and assets, including provisional and permanent vesting. A provision states that the government can appoint a "designated authority" to take over, manage, or sell assets created from foreign funds by an non-governmental organisation whose licence under FCRA was cancelled, suspended, or simply not renewed.

To be sure, a section of the Opposition want to participate in the debate and have argued that the bill was too important to be passed in din.

"I don't know about any decision. As far as my party is concerned, we want to join the debate. We have to register our objections to the bill. The bill is not only against the Christians but against all sections of the society," said Communist Party of India (Marxist) Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas. He added, "The Opposition has a duty to oppose this piece of legislation. It dents the fundamental rights."

A senior Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam leader said, "We need a debate on the bill. The Congress wants diversions. We will not follow the Congress's path." Brittas also pointed out that the Opposition hardly got any opportunity to participate in the debate during the ongoing session. According to PBS Legislative Research data, The Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2025 was the only bill passed after a full debate in this session. The two Houses discussed the bill for total of 17.34 hours.

The Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026 was passed in the Lok Sabha after four minutes of debate. Similarly, The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 could be discussed for three minutes in the Lower House.

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NEW DELHI/CHANDIGARH: A meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Shriamani Akali Dal (SAD) president Sukhbir Singh Badal on Friday reignited speculation that the former allies could revive their alliance ahead of the Punjab assembly elections due early next year, although BJP leaders maintained the party was preparing to contest all 117 seats on its own.

The one-on-one meeting at the Prime Minister's Office in Parliament House complex between the two leaders came years after the SAD walked out of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) in 2020 over the now-repealed farm laws, ending a 23-year alliance that began in 1997.

After the meeting, Badal told reporters that he had met the PM to "discuss issues pertaining to Punjab", but declined to comment on speculation about a political reunion.

Neither the Prime Minister's Office nor the SAD issued an official statement on the meeting till late Friday evening.

However, a senior SAD leader told HT that the possibility of reviving the alliance figured during the discussions. The meeting comes at a time when political activity is gathering pace ahead of the Punjab assembly elections, with the model code of



PM Narendra Modi and SAD chief Sukhbir Badal

conduct expected to come into force later this year. The BJP has repeatedly asserted in recent months that it will contest all 117 assembly seats independently. Reiterating the party's stand, deputy appointed Punjab BJP president Kewal Singh Dhillon said, "Any senior leader can meet the PM. Sukhbir Singh Badal was the deputy CM. I am happy that he must have spoken for the good of Punjab. We will contest all 117 seats in Punjab alone. A major joining is going to happen."

Echoing similar views, BJP national spokesperson RP Singh said, "It does not mean that we are going to have any alliance or compromise. We are preparing to contest elections on all 117 seats, and we are fully prepared to fight and win on all 117 seats. Sukhbir Singh Badal must have had certain issues related to Punjab that he wanted to discuss, which is why he met the Prime Minister," he said.

The BJP and SAD were alliance partners for over two decades and formed governments in

Punjab in 1997, 2007 and 2012. The alliance ended in September 2020 after the Akali Dal withdrew from the NDA in protest against the Centre's three farm laws. Lok Sabha MP Harimant Kaur Badal, Sukhbir Badal's wife, also resigned from the Union cabinet over the issue. The laws were later repealed.

The two parties explored a reunion ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, but talks collapsed over seat sharing. The BJP wanted to contest five of Punjab's 13 parliamentary seats, while the SAD was willing to offer only four. Eventually, both parties stood apart. The Punjab BJP had only one seat while the BJP failed to get its account despite contesting all 13 seats.

In the 2022 assembly election, the first after the alliance ended, the SAD won three seats and the BJP secured two.

AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal took a swipe at the two parties, posting on X, "No karte, poor a tumhile se kar baithe. So, is an alliance forming between the Chandochar Party and the Beas Party?" The PM also had an hour-long meeting with deputy chief minister of Maharashtra, Ekanth Shinde on Friday. The meeting came as the BJP-led government is pushing for a cabinet expansion in the state.

Shinde in a statement said they discussed the "ongoing parliamentary session, the role of Shiv Sena MPs, development works underway and floods."

Bhagwat's outreach to Gen Z sparks slugfest

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NEW DELHI/JAMMU: RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat's remarks defending Gen Z protesters as "not anti-national" triggered sharp political reactions on Friday, with the Congress accusing the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) of running the government from behind the scenes. The BJP, meanwhile, backed the RSS chief's comments and said they should be viewed positively.



Mohan Bhagwat

Bhagwat made the remarks on Thursday while addressing more than 2,000 students in Mumbai, days after student-led protests over the alleged NEET paper leak led to the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan. "If Gen Z is protesting, they are not anti-nationals. They are our own people, our next generation," he said.

Congress general secretary KC Venugopal said Bhagwat's remarks only reinforced the Opposition's allegation that the RSS, and not the elected government, was calling the shots. "RSS is controlling the government. If he has any sincerity towards Gen Z, let him ask the home minister to resign,

Otherwise, at least come to Parliament and apologise to the students and to the Prime Minister also," Venugopal said.

Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said students did not require Bhagwat's endorsement.

Samaajwadi Party MP Ram Gopal Yadav alleged the BJP had turned to Bhagwat only after being "completely cornered" politically and had sent him to "handle the situation". However, in contrast, Jammu and Kashmir CM Omar Abdullah said, "Mohan Bhagwat hasn't said anything that isn't true. Opposing the government is not the same as opposing the country." Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis also backed his remarks and said, "What RSS Sarsangchalak says is not just for one party or one group. He speaks for our country."

'Freedom fighters took bullets, you fear eggs?': SC to TMC MP

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday refused to entertain Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra's plea seeking permission to join police interrogation through video-conferencing in a case over alleged terror funding. The bench dismissed the plea, saying that having "taken the plunge into politics", she could not shy away from appearing before investigators merely because she feared eggs.



Mahua Moitra had sought nod to join police interrogation through video-conferencing

The bench dismissed it as withdrawn. The case arises out of an FIR registered in June at Hoggabara police station in West Bengal's Nadia district on a complaint by BJP leader and Trinamool Congress MP, accusing Moitra of making provocative remarks capable of hurting religious sentiments and disturbing communal harmony. The FIR was registered under alleged offences related to promoting social and religious enmity, outraging religious beliefs, and making statements that cause public mischief.

The complaint relates to two videos uploaded by Moitra on Facebook after a group of BJP workers allegedly gathered outside the Krishnagar Dis-

trict Sessions Court carrying eggs and tomatoes, claiming they would throw them at the MP if she appeared in connection with an election case.

In the first video, Moitra said she would lodge a police complaint against the women seen outside the court with eggs, and if the police refused to register the complaint, she would approach the courts, including the Supreme Court.

In another video posted the following day, she said she would name all the women in an FIR and allegedly remarked that instead of throwing eggs openly, they should do the police seeking quashing of the FIR but directed her to cooperate with the investigation by appearing before the investigating officer on August 14.

To be sure, the impugned high court order had specifically asked the police authorities to ensure that Moitra "shall not be subjected to egg-throwing or any form of harassment."

Tapes implicating Biren in violence manipulated, Manipur govt tells SC

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NEW DELHI: The Manipur government claimed on Friday that an audio tape alleging complicity of former chief minister N Biren Singh in instigating the 2023 Manipur violence was found to be "manipulated" after forensic examination by a national lab and sought dismissal of a petition on the matter with costs.

Appearing before a bench of justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva, additional solicitor general (ASG) Aishwarya Bhatt representing the state said that the tape produced by the petitioner, Kuki Organisation for Human Rights was sent to National Forensic Sciences University (NFSU), Gandhinagar which noted serious manipulations.

"This petition must be dismissed with costs. See what they have done. The report by NFSU, Gandhinagar says that the audio clip supplied by the petitioner had 41 aberrations."

The court directed that a copy of the report be shared with advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioner and said, "It is better if you see a copy of this report. Though I say this confidentially, once it is submitted to us, we cannot take the lawyer by surprise."

Bhushan questioned the report's findings, which contradicted another finding that the dicted another finding that

Modi tells NDA MPs to balance PARL and STATE RESPONSIBILITIES

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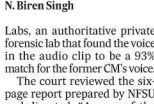
NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday met a group of lawmakers from the National Democratic Alliance and instructed them to participate in parliamentary proceedings while balancing their responsibilities towards their states and the country at large, said people aware of the details.

According to a person aware of the details, the PM interacted with a group that included the 20 rebel Trinamool Congress lawmakers who joined the National Citizens Party of India (NCPI), seven Shiv Sena MPs who switched sides from the Shiv Sena to the National Party (NPP), and two National Congress Party members.

"He was emphatic that as lawmakers we do not have to ignore parliamentary proceedings are not disrupted and we should all work for the welfare and development of our constituencies. He gave the example of the National Party of India will progress when all the states progress," said a person aware of the details.

The PM told the MPs to familiarise themselves with the proceedings, House rules and spend time studying for discussion and debates, the person said.

Manipur govt tells SC



N. Biren Singh

Labs, an authoritative private forensic lab that found the voice in the audio clip to be a 93% match for the former CM's voice.

The court reviewed the six-page report prepared by NFSU and directed, "A copy of the report shall be furnished to the petitioner with colour copy of the annexures." The court specifically directed the petitioner not to make the report public or place it in public domain.

ASG Bhatt told the court that the petitioner should not discredit a national forensic lab in this manner when their material was found to be tampered with. She told the court that at over 40 places in the tape, there were the same vehicle horn and a lady's voice. "This is completely manipulated," she added.

The ethnic clashes in Manipur first began between the Meitei and Kuki communities before involving almost every community. Ethnic clashes left at least 260 people dead and 60,000 displaced. A new state government was formed in February, nearly a year after the imposition of the President's Rule.

GOVT, STUDENTS HOLD FIRST TALKS IN JHARKHAND

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RANCHI: The Jharkhand government and students held their first talks on Friday, following alleged irregularities in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) examinations held the first round of talks on Friday.

While the student representatives said they will continue their agitation, state minister Sudhaya Kumar said the government was considering the students' demands "sympathetically".

"We listened to the demands of the students and assured them we would consider their demands sympathetically," Kumar, who was part of a team of four ministers who are talking to the protesters, said.

Only senior cops may probe cybercrime cases

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NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has proposed amending the Information Technology (IT) Act to require that investigations of cybercrimes by police officers senior to the rank of inspector, according to a parliamentary committee on Friday.

The proposal has been sent to the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) following a recommendation by the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Home Affairs, which was part of a team of four ministers who are talking to the protesters, said.

THIRD ROUND OF TALKS BETWEEN META AND GOVT

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) on Friday held a third round of discussion with Meta's legal team, one with the company's technical team, focusing on the functioning of its platform algorithms, two people aware of the matter said.

The 77th meeting, led by Electronics Minister and chaired by Nitya Sekharia S Krishnan, is part of the government's continuing engagement with Meta after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Facebook Reel was temporarily restricted on July 28 allegedly due to an error in the company's automated systems.

The government is seeking a better understanding of Meta's algorithms, content moderation policies and safeguards for high-profile accounts, particularly the systems that determine whether content is restricted or removed in India. A senior IT ministry source said one with the company's automated systems.

Ministry issues I-Day invites with Vande Mataram lyrics

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NEW DELHI: Invitation cards issued by the defence ministry for this year's Independence Day ceremony at the Red Fort include the lyrics of Vande Mataram, which will be played for the first time at the annual celebrations during the hoisting of the national flag, officials aware of the matter said on Friday.

The cards carry the lyrics of all six stanzas of the national song, the officials said. The song will be played before the national anthem at the 80th Independence Day celebrations.

Top ministers, military officers, bureaucrats, diplomats, students, and special guests who have excelled across fields are usually invited for the ceremony.

THE CARDS CARRY THE LYRICS OF ALL SIX STANZAS OF THE NATIONAL SONG, WHICH WILL BE PLAYED AT THE 80TH I-DAY CELEBRATIONS

for offenders. The law currently safeguards the national flag, the national anthem and the Constitution.

The move came amid celebrations for the 150th year of Vande Mataram, and a few months after the Centre made the rendition of all six stanzas of the song mandatory, as against the decades-old practice of singing the first two stanzas that were adopted as the national song in 1950.

"People know the national song by heart, but few can sing the national song. The lyrics have been provided so that people can sing along," said one of the officials cited above. The invitation cards also feature an image of Swami Vivekananda, the Prime Minister of India, and a few lines of the song.

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India issues names for 27 Arunachal sites

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NEW DELHI: India on Friday issued standard names for 27 places and geographical features in Arunachal Pradesh located along the Line of Actual Control (LAC), a move officials described as a riposte to China's efforts to rename dozens of locations in Indian state in recent years.

This is the first time India has issued the names on a cartographic map.

Among the places included in list is the border village of Longlu, which has been controlled by the Indian claim line, they added on condition of anonymity. The move is aimed at reinforcing India's absolute sovereign and legal jurisdiction over these territories.

An official statement from the Union home ministry said the Indian government, in consultation with the government of Arunachal Pradesh, "identified a total of 27 places or features in Arunachal Pradesh, by standard place and feature names on the official maps of Survey of India (SoI)".

"Identifying them formally on the Survey of India map of Arunachal Pradesh is aimed at facilitating their accurate recognition and better awareness among the public at large," the statement said.

The home ministry said the locations identified on the Survey of India map include 21 land areas, four passes, a lake and a monument. The land locations are Longlu, Maja, Bissa, Bara Kundun, Chhotu Kundun, Dhan Bari, Pritnagar, Buddhnamdir, Jainpur, Toringnagar, Ramnagar, Jassant Garh, Sagar, Padma, Jyotnagar, Baisakhi, Chhotu Ropuk, Bara Ropuk, Shivaji Nagar, Sunpura and Kamlang Nagar.

The passes are Doo La, Riza La, Pokur La and Thag La, and the list includes Sambho Sarovar lake and Sher-e-Thapa Memorial.

An official familiar with the development said: "There has been a lot of ambiguity regarding the maps. China uses this to give fictitious names to Arunachal Pradesh's territories, which are part of sovereign India."

"Putting these 27 locations on the Survey of India map provides clarity, makes our claim status strong and strengthens the official documentation of geographical features."

Over the past few years, China has repeatedly announced its own "standardised names" for dozens of places in Arunachal Pradesh as part of its claims on Indian territory. China refers to Arunachal Pradesh as "south Tibet" and there

Arunachal CM to seek Army's take on Chinese incursion buzz

ITANAGAR: Arunachal Pradesh chief minister Pema Khandu on Friday said he has invited representatives of the Nah Welfare Society (NWS), an organisation for the Nah tribe, for a meeting and will seek clarification from the Indian Army over reports alleging a Chinese incursion near Tasing in Arunachal Pradesh's Upper Subansiri district.

Khandu said he was not convinced that an incursion had taken place and expressed confi-

dence in the Indian Army's ability to safeguard the country's borders.

"I have invited the members of the Nah Welfare Society and will personally verify the matter. I will also speak to the Indian Army and verify the same," the chief minister said.

He said the army was performing its duty of protecting Indian territory and that the state government would ascertain the facts before making any further comments on the reports.



DAMEN LEPCHA

documentation of geographical features."

Over the past few years, China has repeatedly announced its own "standardised names" for dozens of places in Arunachal Pradesh as part of its claims on Indian territory. China refers to Arunachal Pradesh as "south Tibet" and there

have been instances of Chinese authorities issuing stapled visas to residents of Arunachal Pradesh.

In November 2025, India registered a strong protest after a woman from Arunachal Pradesh was detained by Chinese authorities at Shanghai airport on the grounds that her Indian passport

was invalid.

The officials said identifying a place on the Survey of India map gives administrative and governance value to it, as mapped places are easier to reference in land, revenue and census records, infrastructure planning, and border road construction.

They also said the move is aimed at discrediting China's efforts to assign "fictitious names" to places in Arunachal Pradesh.

In April this year, after China assigned names to 23 locations in Arunachal Pradesh, the external affairs ministry said such attempts to manufacture "baseless narratives" would take the reality and could even hit efforts to normalise bilateral relations.

External affairs ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at the time that India categorically rejects "any mischievous attempts by the Chinese side to assign fictitious names to places which form part of the territory of India." He added, "China should refrain from actions which inject negativity into relations and undermine efforts to create better understanding."

Jaiswal said such moves by

China, aimed at introducing false claims, cannot alter the "undeniable reality that these places and territories, including Arunachal Pradesh, were, are, and will always remain an integral and inalienable part of India".

China's ministry of civil affairs, which is responsible for standardising the names of geographical features in "south Tibet", had issued a notification renaming the 23 locations, including rivers, mountains and towns.

In the past too, India has rejected China's moves to rename dozens of locations in Arunachal Pradesh, including towns, rivers and geographic features, arguing that such actions will not change the reality. China has resorted to such renaming exercises in 2017, 2021, 2023 and 2024, usually during periods of strained relations.

India and China are currently normalising their relations, which plummeted to an all-time low due to a military standoff on the LAC that began in 2020 and lasted more than four years. As part of this process of normalisation, the two countries have held talks aimed at resolving their long-standing border dispute.

Parl panel calls for tighter security at J&K tourist spots

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NEW DELHI: A parliamentary panel on home affairs has recommended developing an integrated security and surveillance framework, incorporating comprehensive CCTV coverage, centralised monitoring facilities, regular vulnerability assessments and periodic security audits at all major tourist destinations in Jammu and Kashmir.

The panel's suggestions come a year after 25 tourists and a pony operator were killed by three Pakistani terrorists in Patalgama's Baisaran meadow on April 22, 2025, triggering a four-day armed conflict between India and Pakistan.

The panel has further asked the government to prescribe and review clear inter-agency standard operating procedures (SOPs) before every peak tourist season to ensure a coordinated and timely response to any security-related incident.

A delegation of department related standing committee on home affairs, led by Dr Radha Mohan Das Agrawal, visited Gulmarg on May 13 and Sonmarg on May 14 to undertake an on-the-spot assessment of the security arrangements at major tourist destinations and to review the preparedness measures in place for ensuring the safety and convenience of tourists.

The committee appreciates the comprehensive security arrangements put in place by the Union Territory administration and the Jammu and Kashmir Police at Gulmarg and other major tourist and religious destinations. The committee, however, recommended that an integrated security and surveillance framework be developed for all major tourist destinations, incorporating comprehensive CCTV coverage, centralised monitoring facilities, regular vulnerability assessments and periodic security audits," the panel said in its 26th report, tabled in Parliament on Friday.

The committee further recommends that clear inter-agency standard operating procedures be prescribed and reviewed before every peak tourist season to ensure a coordinated and timely response to any security-related



A delegation visited Gulmarg on May 13 and Sonmarg on May 14 for an on-the-spot assessment.

incident," the report states.

The panel further recommended that the "existing inter-agency coordination mechanism be further institutionalised through a unified command-and-control framework, clearly defined responsibilities and real-time information-sharing protocols".

"Periodic joint security audits and vulnerability assessments should also be conducted, particularly before the commencement of the tourist season and the Yatra, to identify and address emerging security concerns," it said.

Security at border

Committee members also visited Drass and Kargil on May 15 to assess border security management and operational preparedness of the armed forces.

At Post 43 in Kargil, the committee members interacted with army personnel and obtained a first-hand understanding of border management practices, terrain and other operational considerations.

For these sensitive sectors, the panel has recommended "sustained investment in integrated intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance capabilities, counter-drone systems, secure communication networks and indigenous high-altitude technologies".

It has further asked the ministry of defence to ensure their "timely procurement, deployment and periodic technological upgradation in all strategically important sectors". It also recommended accelerated development of all-weather roads, tunnels, bridges, advanced storage facilities, forward logistics hubs and alternative supply routes.

India discusses Brahmaputra dam with China at WMCC meet

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NEW DELHI: India and China have held talks on boundary delimitation, border management and trans-border cooperation, with New Delhi emphasising the need for China to share technical details on upstream projects on trans-border rivers.

These issues figured in the 36th meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs (WMCC) in New Delhi on Thursday, according to a read-out from the external affairs ministry on Friday. The Indian side underlined that maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas is "essential for the overall development of bilateral relations".

WMCC, which last met in Beijing on May 27, played a crucial role in managing tensions during the military face-off on the Line of

Actual Control (LAC) that lasted more than four years and ended when the two sides reached an understanding in October 2024.

The two sides "engaged in frank discussions" and reviewed the situation along LAC, the read-out said.

As a follow up to outcomes of the 24th round of talks between the Special Representatives on the border issue last year, the two sides had "detailed exchanges on issues related to boundary delimitation, border management, mechanism-building and trans-border cooperation".

The readout said: "The Indian side reiterated the need for early convening of the next meeting of the Expert Level Mechanism on trans-border rivers and emphasised the importance of sharing technical details on upstream projects."

This was a reference to India's concerns about a mega dam being built by China on the upper

reaches of the Brahmaputra river. The \$137-billion dam on the Yarlung Tsangpo river is expected to produce three times more energy than China's Three Gorges Dam, currently the world's largest.

But there are fears that the dam on the eastern rim of the ecologically fragile Tibetan plateau will have severe environmental impacts that can affect millions downstream in India and Bangladesh.

Even at the last meeting of the WMCC in May, the Indian side had stressed on an "early meeting" of the Expert Level Mechanism on trans-border rivers.

The Indian side has flagged its concerns about the mega dam to China and emphasised the need for transparency and consultations with downstream countries. The Yarlung Tsangpo becomes the Siang when it enters India's Arunachal Pradesh state, and then the Brahmaputra in Assam before flowing into Bangladesh.

India eyes France-led 6th-gen aircraft project

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NEW DELHI: India is taking steps to join a France-led programme for the development of a sixth-generation fighter aircraft, the defence ministry informed a Parliamentary panel that tabled its report in both Houses on Friday.

"The Ministry of Defence has initiated efforts in a concerted manner to co-join the 6th Generation Fighter Aircraft Development Programme viz. Future Combat Air System (FCAS) spearheaded by the French Government," the ministry told the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Defence.

The Indian Air Force, the world's fourth largest, had earlier zeroed in on two global consortia—France, Germany, and Spain (FCAS) and the UK, Italy and Japan (Global Combat Air Programme)—hoping to join forces with one of them to develop the sixth-generation fighter aircraft.

India's pathway to joining the

France-led initiative remains unclear, as FCAS no longer exists in its originally envisaged format—France and Germany scrapped the joint project in June. If India decides to move ahead, the programme may progress under a new arrangement.

"Detailed status report in development of acquisition of Sixth-Generation (GG) Aircrafts and any roadmap prepared along with tentative timeline for acquisition of such Aircrafts may be given at the time of submitting Action Taken Statement for the perusal of the Committee," the panel said in its report.

India is likely to join a global consortium developing a sixth-generation fighter aircraft—the world's most advanced—because the IAF does not want to lag in deploying this capability to meet future air threats, then Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan told the panel that tabled a report on the subject in March too.

INDIA REITERATES NO ROLE IN HASINA PRESSER

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NEW DELHI: The Indian government on Friday again distanced itself from Bangladesh premier Sheikh Hasina's news conference in New Delhi, which triggered a strong response from Dhaka, and said it had no role in the event and didn't endorse anything said against the Bangladesh government.

Bangladesh's foreign ministry and surveillance framework be developed for all major tourist destinations, incorporating comprehensive CCTV coverage, centralised monitoring facilities, regular vulnerability assessments and periodic security audits," the panel said in its 26th report, tabled in Parliament on Friday.

The committee further recommends that clear inter-agency standard operating procedures be prescribed and reviewed before every peak tourist season to ensure a coordinated and timely response to any security-related

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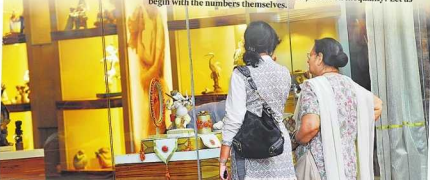
NUMBER THEORY

Everyone has an explanation for the world's biggest events. **Number Theory** tests those explanations against the evidence. Through rigorous analysis, data and fact-based reporting, it uncovers surprising insights, challenges conventional wisdom and reveals the bigger picture behind the issues shaping India and the world.

What is the actual economic inequality in India?

By Roshan Kishore and Abhishek Jha

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged Indians to cut down on gold purchases and foreign travel amid concerns over India's external balance, he was subtly hinting towards a deeper problem in the Indian economy. There is now a significant cohort of Indians whose lifestyle is at par with the rich in high-income countries and who are way ahead of how ordinary Indians earn and spend. This cohort seems to have become bigger over time, as is seen in India's rising trade deficit after economic reforms. But, statistically economic reforms, how does one square this (counter-intuitive statistical) circle on inequality? Let us begin with the numbers themselves.



1

The really-rich have seen the lowest increase in spending after reforms

India's first income survey is in the process of being conducted. Existing estimates of inequality are based on consumption expenditure surveys (CES) conducted by the National Statistical Office (NSO). Comparing the monthly per capita expenditure (MPCE) of the entire CES, top 10%, top 5% and top 1% between 1993-94 and 2023-24 CES reveals – the earliest and latest after 1991 reforms – shows that top 1% have seen the lowest proportionate increase in their MPCE. The catch up of the masses vis-a-vis the classes is almost entirely a result of the former's high growth in non-food spending.

Consumption growth between 2023-24 & 1993-94

Chart shows ratio of Monthly Per Capita Expenditure between 2023-24 and 1993-94

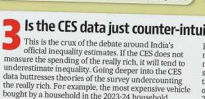
	Total
Top 1%	11.1
Top 5%	12.9
Top 10%	13.6
All classes	15.3



	Food
Top 1%	10.7
Top 5%	10.5
Top 10%	10.6
All classes	11.2



	Non-Food
Top 1%	11.3
Top 5%	14.6
Top 10%	15.9
All classes	21.6



Source: HT analysis using NSO data

2

Inequality seems to have fallen even within the really rich

Thanks to the trend described above, India's consumption inequality has fallen in the post-reform period. The Gini coefficient – the most widespread statistical measure of inequality where 0 shows perfect equality and 1 perfect inequality – has fallen from 0.32 in 1993-94 to 0.29 in 2023-24.

What about inequality within the really rich though? It makes sense to ask this question because it is eminently likely that the super-rich (those who own the rich (say, those who own a car) and only the former has seen income rise. Data seems to suggest otherwise once again. Intra-class Gini has seen the sharpest fall among the richest classes between 1993-94 and 2023-24.

Within-class Gini coefficient of MPCE

	Top 1%
1993-94	0.28
2023-24	0.15



	Top 5%
1993-94	0.24
2023-24	0.17



	Top 10%
1993-94	0.23
2023-24	0.18



	Overall
1993-94	0.33
2023-24	0.29



Gini coefficient takes value between 0 and 1 where 0 denotes perfect equality and 1 perfect inequality. Source: HT analysis using NSO data

3

Is the CES data just counter-intuitive or really not representative?

This is the crux of the debate around India's official inequality estimate. If the CES does not underestimate inequality, going deeper into the data buttresses theories of the survey undercounting the really rich. For example, the most expensive vehicle bought by a household in the 2023-24 household consumption expenditure survey (HCES) cost just Rs 45 lakh. The share of such households in the HCES is eight households per million. This does not really seem to fit consumption standard of India's super rich. For example, according to the Ministry of Road Transport and Vahan (roadworth), 4,128 Jaguar, 877 Porsche 911 Carrera, 11 McLaren, and six Aston Martin four wheelers were registered in the country in FY 2023-24. makers that typically sell cars priced significantly above

Its 45 lakh in India. This non-enthusiastic count of 5,205 registrations amounts to a share of 16 households per million using population projections and household size from the HCES. The CES might be undercounting the rich at a wider level than just luxury cars. The share of households/population who spent on air travel in 2011-12 and 2023-24 shows a decline from 649 households/75 people per million to 471 households/609 people per million. The number of domestic air passengers in India increased from 68.6 million to 153.7 million during this period, according to the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), which translates to roughly 49,993 departures per million and 1,30,381 departures per million people in 2011-12 and 2023-24 respectively. This means that the average Indian air traveller would have to take 230 trips in 2024-25 instead of 65 in 2011-12 annually for the 16-25 data to be correct.

Domestic air passengers and estimated air travellers

	Domestic air passengers per million people: DGCA	Estimated air ticket buyers per million people: CES/HCS
2011-12	774.8	49,993.26
2023-24	469.04	110,390.58



Source: CES 2014-15, CES 2023-24, DGCA, National Commission on Population

If the CES is undercounting air travellers, can it be trusted to represent people spending on even higher value goods and services? And if the super rich are undercounted, how credible are its estimates of economic inequality? This does not, however, mean the CES is a useless statistical database. Sure, it tends to undercount the rich, but it also gives a treasure trove of information on the economic condition of a vast majority of Indians. The numbers above only tell us that one should take the inequality measures from the CES data with some amount of skepticism.

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Rahul says E20 big issue, destroying people's vehicles
NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday said E20 was a "big issue" and the blended fuel was stealing from people and destroying their vehicles. Gandhi alleged that "there is so much corruption" all over. He said the Congress would take the matter up "in a big way" because it is "destroying people's scooters, destroying people's lives, and literally is stealing directly from them."

Security guard held in Badrinath donation case
GOPESHWAR: Police on Friday arrested a security guard of a private hydropower project in Uttarakhand's Joshimath in connection with the alleged financial irregularities involving donations and offerings at the Badrinath temple, officials said. Valuable metal items and other articles believed to have been taken from the temple offerings were recovered from the accused's residence, police said. The arrest is the third in the case, which came to light last month.

Ghee supply gaps case: Former TDB president booked
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The special investigation team probing allegations of irregularities in the supply of Milana ghee at the Sahakarimala temple has booked former Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) president PS Prasanth and two others in the case, an officer said. The FIR was registered on Thursday before a vigilance court in Kollam and also names former TDB member A Ajikumar and former administrative officer Murali Babu, who died on June 13.

3 of 6.5k KP families resettled in Valley

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NEW DELHI: Only three of 6,500 Kashmiri migrant families that initially expressed willingness to return to the region have permanently resettled in the Valley, a Parliamentary panel observed, asking the government to undertake a comprehensive assessment of the security, housing, livelihood, education and social concerns that are holding them back.

"The committee observes that, despite 6,510 families initially expressing willingness to return, only three families have permanently resettled in the Kashmir Valley. It, therefore, recommends a comprehensive assessment of the security, housing, livelihood, education and social concerns inhibiting return, including a structured survey of migrant families residing outside the Union Territory (of J&K), so that the rehabilitation package may be suitably reviewed and a safe, voluntary and dignified return facilitated," the department related standing committee on home affairs said in its 26th report, tabled in Parliament on Friday. The report, however, doesn't mention when these families expressed willingness.

During its visit to J&K from May 11 to 15, the panel led by Dr Radha Mohan Das Agrawal, sought detailed information regarding the rehabilitation of displaced Hindu migrant populations, including the number of displaced families, restoration and protection of migrant properties, settlement of pending legal and ownership-related issues, rehabilitation of returnees, etc.

OVER 6,000 FAMILIES SHOWED INTEREST IN SCHEME THAT GAVE ₹7.50L AID TO THOSE RETURNING PERMANENTLY

tion policies and the status of migrants residing outside J&K with regard to their willingness to return to the Kashmir Valley.

The J&K administration informed the panel that as part of the comprehensive efforts for relief, rehabilitation and dignified return of Kashmiri migrants, a financial assistance of ₹7.50 lakh per family is offered for migrant families willing to return and permanently settle in Kashmir Valley. A large number of Kashmiri Pandit families left their ancestral homes with the onset of militancy in J&K in 1980s. A smaller number of Sikh and Muslim families also migrated.

Ajay Dhar, 51, from Baramulla, who now lives in Jammu's Ban Talab, said there is no sense of security among the Pandits. "After 36 years, when price of realty has soared up, how can Pandits buy plots and how can they raise their houses when they have sold their land, ₹7.5 lakh is too less."

Sunil Pandita, 47, who lives in Jagti, too, said: "Even to this date, Pandits in Valley are advised by none else than local police to not go to their native villages citing movement of militants. So, insecurity is there. Second, ₹7.50 lakh is not an amount to raise or rebuild a

house. Third, Pandits... do not exactly know that who burnt their houses post 1990s."

A government employee, who declined to be named, said: "Around 5,500 employees have been given employment in Kashmir under PM's package since 2010. However, till date most have not been given government flats."

In a Parliament reply in December 2022, the MHA had stated that terrorists had killed nine Pandits since 2020. According to the data shared by J&K administration with the panel, as on date, a total of 48,451 migrant families comprising 1,62,087 persons are registered with the Relief Organisation (migrants), Jammu and Kashmir. Of these, 47,466 Kashmiri migrant families comprising 1,59,057 persons and 985 Jammu migrant families comprising 3,030 people are registered under the Relief Organisation. Most displaced families settled in Jammu but some also moved to other states.

The panel report, citing information provided by local administration, notes that since no formal institutional mechanism existed during the initial period of migration for maintaining records of families residing outside Jammu and Kashmir, precise data regarding such families is not available. "...the administration estimates that approximately 21,500 migrant families are presently residing in Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru, Mumbai, Pune and other metropolitan cities."

With inputs from Ravi Krishan Khajuria

ARMY ENHANCED 'NON-KINETIC' OPS CAPABILITY: PARL PANEL INFORMED

NEW DELHI: The Indian Army has significantly enhanced its capabilities in cyber warfare, electronic warfare, information operations, and electromagnetic spectrum management, strengthening its capacity to conduct operations across the non-kinetic domain, the defence ministry informed a Parliamentary panel that tabled its report in both houses on Friday.

It is also integrating the play of drone capabilities of the three services to maximise operational effectiveness.

"Dedicated cyber units focus on securing critical networks and conducting cyber operations. Electronic Warfare units are being equipped with advanced systems for spectrum dominance and the Indian Army is integrating counter-drone capabilities across all stakeholders to establish a unified counter- unmanned aerial system grid," the ministry told the Parliamentary standing committee on defence.

Drones and counter-drone warfare was in the spotlight during Operation Sindoor, the four-day military clash between India and Pakistan after the Pahalgaon terror attack last year. To be sure, India is preparing to initiate far-reaching military reforms to ensure its armed forces are ready for future battlefield challenges.

Information operations have been refined to counter adversarial narratives in the cognitive domain, the panel was told.

"Emphasis on indigenous technology, artificial intelligence and specialised training is ensuring readiness to address the evolving challenges of hybrid warfare in a comprehensive and integrated manner,"

No compromise on Cauvery, Mokedatu dam halt: TN CM

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Friday said there would be no compromise on the Cauvery issue or on fighting against the construction of the Mokedatu dam in Karnataka, adding that the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) had no intention of playing politics over the dam issue.

"On the Cauvery issue, some members have asked for details. Cauvery is our lifeline; it is an emotional issue for us," Vijay said in his first comments on the issue during the Tamil Nadu assembly session on Friday.

Recalling that the assembly passed an unanimous resolution in June and sent it to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Vijay said: "On learning that the Union Minister of State for Jal Shakti had not mentioned full details regarding the dam, we immediately wrote another letter to the Prime Minister."

VIJAY SAID THE PROPOSED VISIT TO B'LURU WAS AN ATTEMPT TO SEE IF DIALOGUE COULD WORK

He underscored that his government would not yield even a fraction of Tamil Nadu's rights on sharing Cauvery river water with Karnataka or stopping the construction of the dam at Mokedatu. "That is our clear stand," Vijay said, while adding that the proposed visit to Bengaluru was an attempt to see if a dialogue could work between the two

states. Responding to the leader of the opposition from DMK Uthayachandran Stalin, who raised the TVK in a special calling attention motion, Vijay traced how Tamil Nadu had handled the issue since 1969 — from considering dialogue to sticking to legal recourse. Vijay said that his government is firm on dealing with the Cauvery issue legally and that there is no change about it.

Opposition leader Stalin pointed out that political parties in Karnataka stand united despite political differences on the issue and that is why he has been demanding the ruling TVK government convene an all-party meeting.

Stalin asked, "What is your fear and hesitation in holding the all-party meeting? He said Karnataka had shown unity, held an all-party meeting on the issue and considered stakeholders' representations."

Vijay's wife withdraws petition to divorce him

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C. Joseph Vijay and Sangeetha

BENGALURU: Sangeetha, the wife of Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay, on Friday withdrew her divorce petition filed before the family court in Chengalpattu, near Chennai. Judge D Sujatha allowed Sangeetha to withdraw the plea after the latter appeared through video conferencing and confirmed that she did not wish to pursue the proceedings.

The court issued notice to Vijay's counsel, who said they had no objection to the request. The court therefore, allowed Sangeetha to withdraw the petition and granted her liberty to file a fresh petition in future, if required.

Sangeetha had filed the divorce petition in February under Section 27(1)(a), (b) and (d) of the Special Marriage Act, alleging adultery and mental cruelty. She had told the court at the time that she had tried to resolve their differences amicably but failed. She had also said

she delayed legal proceedings to protect her children's studies and emotional well-being. She had also sought maintenance and the right to live in the couple's Neelankarai residence.

At the previous hearing on June 20 this year, both Vijay and Sangeetha had failed to appear before the court. Their lawyers had then sought permission for their clients to appear virtually, citing security concerns and procedural difficulties arising from their status as public figures.

On Friday, after recording Sangeetha's statement and noting Vijay's lack of objection, Judge Sujatha dismissed the petition as withdrawn.

M.P. ARMS FOREST PERSONNEL, GIVES IMMUNITY TO USE

BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh government has decided to rearm forest personnel with firearms after four years, granting them immunity similar to police officers in cases of use. The order came into effect on Friday, amid mounting threats to conservation efforts in protected and reserved forest areas.

The decision follows a recent directive from the Madhya Pradesh high court, which sought a reply from the state government on the security of forest officials after 8 personnel were injured in June during an anti-encroachment drive in Khandwa.

In a gazette notification issued on Friday, the government cited the growing vulnerability of forest land, wildlife, and forest based resources as the reason for restoring firearms to forest staff. "The use of firearms in the discharge of duty could expose forest staff to criminal proceedings. To address this, the government has extended immunity from prosecution without prior sanction, in line with directions issued by the Supreme Court," the notification said. **SHRUTI TOMAR**

Man shot in gun display dies in ambulance crash

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AIMER: A hotel staffer, who was shot during a gun display, was killed on Friday after the ambulance rushing him to hospital crashed into a drain's boundary while trying to avoid a stray animal along the Jodhpur highway in Rajasthan, police said.

The deceased has been identified as Ram Kumar (40), originally from Bihar, worked at Khumar's Neelkanth hotel. Police said the



The ambulance crashed into a drain's boundary while trying to avoid an animal in Nagar.

incident took place after liquor trader Mahipal Bisnoi arrived in

the hotel at around 3.30 am and allegedly showed his country-made pistol to Ram Kumar. "While he was showing him the gun, there was a misfire and Ram Kumar was shot," said additional superintendent of police Asaram Choudhary. He added that the bullet entered Kumar's chest and exited from near his shoulder. Bisnoi fled the spot immediately.

Police said the ambulance taking Kumar to a hospital in Jodhpur allegedly swerved to avoid a stray animal on the highway near

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Must harmonise RTI, data privacy law: SC

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday said that the Right to Information Act must be harmonised with the protection of personal information under the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act 2023. The court observed further that the Centre must spell out the criteria to determine violations under the digital privacy law.

Hearing a batch of petitions challenging the 2023 amendment to the RTI Act that removed the public interest clause for disclosure of personal information, a bench led by CJI Surya Kant said, "We need to harmonise the RTI law and the DPDP Act as both are central statutes. The question therefore is whether there can be a blanket prohibition on disclosure of all digital personal information or we should adopt a proportionate approach."

SG Tushar Mehta said that the Centre would file an affidavit

responding to the petitions within two weeks. "It is not a case that is as bad as portrayed by the petitioners. There is a balance the legislation has sought to bring about..."

The court said that an enquiry into the validity of the 2023 amendment will essentially require the court to examine the extent to which protection offered for personal information satisfies the Constitutional test.

Advocates Vrinda Grover and Prashant Bhushan, appearing for some petitioners, said that the amendment materially altered the purpose for which the RTI Act was enacted.

Grover said that the earlier regime provided safeguards for privacy. However this stands replaced by a blanket ban, which violates the fundamental right to information under Article 19.

Bhushan pointed out that the amendment itself set aside the knell on investigative journalism as they will be barred from reporting on corruption without the offender's permission.

Centre mulling framework to check 'offensive' OTT content

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NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (MIB) is considering a statutory framework to regulate OTT content considered offensive to society's moral standards, according to a parliamentary committee report tabled in the Lok Sabha by BJP MP Satish Kumar Gautam on Friday. The proposed framework may also provide for an independent post-release review panel to examine flagged content and recommend corrective action.

The development was disclosed by the Home Ministry on August 7 in its response to the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Home Affairs, which had examined the regulation of OTT platforms and the protection of children from inappropriate content.

According to the report, seen by HT, a "comprehensive statutory framework mechanism" to

A PARLIAMENTARY STANDING PANEL SUGGESTED SETUP OF AN INDEPENDENT REVIEW PANEL

regulate programmes aired on OTT platforms that are offensive to societal moral standards is under consideration.

The committee has recommended setting up an independent "post release review panel" comprising experts from child development, education, law, social sciences and civil society.

Explaining the panel's role, the committee report said, "...the Post Release Review Panel will watch the flagged or trending content post release based on user complaints submitted through a standardised grievance mechanism. The Committee recommends that the Panel shall devise suitable norms and

guidelines keeping in view the cultural ethos and sensitivity of the country. The Committee further recommends that the panel may also work out suitable penalties in case of infringement of these norms/guidelines."

The committee has also recommended that the proposed statutory framework include technology-enabled age verification and stronger parental controls that go beyond simple self-declaration to prevent minors from accessing age-inappropriate content. It has also suggested penalties for non-compliance.

The report, however, does not specify a timeline for introducing the proposed framework or indicate whether the government has finalised its structure.

The committee noted that the current regulatory framework under the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, relies largely on self-regulation and a three-tier grievance redressal mechanism.

INDIA TO GET 2ND SPACEPORT, TO BE RUN BY PVT FIRM

MUMBAI: India's second under-construction spaceport in Tamil Nadu, set to launch small satellites up to 500kgs, will be operated by a private Indian firm.

On Friday, the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre, which is single window nodal autonomous agency under the Department of Space, floated an Expression of Interest from Indian industries for the operation and management of the Small Satellite Launch Vehicle Launch Complex (SLC) at Kulasekarpattinam in Thoothukudi district in Tamil Nadu. The decision comes in the backdrop of the Indian Space Policy-2023 that opened space operations to private sector participation.

"The IN-SPACe through ISRO will facilitate the handing over of facilities established in SLC to selected party for operation and management..." the EIO said. HTc

KVS exam results will be out in phases: CBSE

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MUMBAI: The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Friday announced that the Tier-II examination results for recruitment to teaching and non-teaching posts in Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan (KVS), Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti (NVS) and Ekavya Model Residential Schools (EMRS) will be declared in phases from mid-August, days after candidates raised concerns over the delay in recruitment results.

In a statement, the board said the Tier-II examinations held in March covered recruitment to various teaching and non-teaching posts and included both objective and descriptive papers.

According to CBSE, the evaluation of the objective papers has been completed, including the release of answer keys and OMR sheet images.

The physical assessment of over 210,000 descriptive answer books across 68 subjects was at an advanced stage, said the board.

It added that results would be announced in phases beginning mid-August and advised candidates to follow updates only through its official website.

HT had reported on August 1 that millions of aspirants were awaiting the outcome of the recruitment process for 23,029 posts across KVS, NVS and EMRS.

The delay had triggered an online campaign, wherein candidates urged the government to expedite their declaration.

AMRITSAR POLICE COMMISSIONER BHULLAR SHIFTED

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CHANDIGARH: The Punjab government on Friday transferred Amritsar commissioner of police Gurpreet Singh Bhullar, days after his claims of a busting a Pakistan-backed terror module trying to attack the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar triggered a row.

The Aam Aadmi Party-led government posted Bhullar at DGP's office in Chandigarh till further orders and gave charge to Border Range DGP Harmanbir Singh Gill. A 2004-batch Punjab cadre IPS officer, Bhullar had taken over in November 2023.

On August 4, he had addressed media to announce the arrest of nine people, including four minors, in connection with an alleged terror module that he claimed also tried to haul petrol bombs at the protest site in Jantar Mantar.

Bhullar did not respond to HT's repeated requests for comment till late on Friday.

Pvt bill seeks curbs on U-13 social media use

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NEW DELHI: Children under 13 could be barred from creating accounts on social media and online gaming platforms without verified parental consent, while platforms could be prohibited from tracking, profiling or targeting minors with personalised advertising, according to a proposed private member's bill.

The Safeguarding Healthy Internet Environments for Little Digital-Natives (SHIELD) Bill, 2025, also proposes mandatory age-verification systems for platforms accessible to minors and parental control dashboards that would allow guardians to monitor activity, manage privacy settings and restrict screen time.

The bill, proposed by BJP MP Bajrang Pandey, was among two private members' bills that were scheduled to be introduced in the parliament on Friday but could not be taken up because of adjournments of the House. The

second bill is a proposed law seeking to regulate the misuse of artificial intelligence (AI) to create realistic imitations of people. However, private members' bills rarely make it into law, with only about a dozen having cleared parliament since Independence.

The SHIELD Bill defines a child as anyone below 18 and seeks to impose a dedicated set of safety obligations on social media services, online gaming platforms and other digital intermediaries. It proposes to prohibit platforms from tracking, profiling or using personalised advertising for children.

Platforms would also have to take steps to prevent children from being exposed to pornography, gambling and simulated betting, violent or extremist material and drug-related content. Platforms violating the proposed law could face penalties of up to ₹10 crore. Repeated or wilful violations could result in temporary suspension or blocking of services under Section 69A of the Information Technology Act.

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{ OUR TAKE }

A problem of walking the talk

The actions of RSS affiliates & the BJP don't reflect the signals from Mohan Bhagwat's Gen Z outreach

There are three interesting aspects of RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat's mega outreach to young people this week. The first is the timing and background of the 2,000 student-strong event — weeks after tens of thousands of students pushed out the Union education minister and aired long-simmering grievances about jobs and education. Many belonged to Gen Z — born between 1997 and 2012 — which will become the largest cohort of the Indian population ahead of the 2029 general elections. Without falling into easy political stereotypes of left-right-wing — after all, Gen Z is not only the reel-making, English-speaking urban middle-class, but also the Kanwariyas and Shakhya dwellers, the delivery executives and small-town strivers grinding it out in test-prep centres — it is clear that a new culture of communication and conversation is taking root. Gen Z's priorities and concerns differ from those who came before it, shaped not only by the political atmosphere but also by the climate crisis, the gloomy economic outlook and the global turmoil. As one of the longest serving RSS chiefs, Bhagwat has clearly recognised that he needs to shed the ideals of the RSS in a new generation and dispel notions that it is an outdated, conservative body out of step with modern lives.

Two, Bhagwat's comments on the youth, education, LGBTQIA+ rights and reservations underline just how much the RSS has moved on core ideological issues — at least in speech. Forged as a vehicle for orthodox Hindu revivalism, its worldview was once anchored in traditional hierarchies, using the chimera of social cohesion to further cultural conservatism; it viewed caste-based reservations, civil rights, and "modern" ideas of gender and sexuality with suspicion. First on caste (by assiduously bringing Dalit and tribal people within its fold, that too from a young age) and now on social relations and protests, the RSS has attempted to move with the times. No doubt, democratic politics, electoral calculus, and shifting societal values have compelled the recalibration. Under Bhagwat, the RSS has projected a more inclusive front — whether it is saying the youth have a right to protest, their concerns are genuine, acknowledging problems in the education system, or that LGBTQIA+ rights, including that of companionship, need consideration.

Three, unfortunately, the words and signals from Bhagwat's outreach are not adequately reflected in the actions of either RSS affiliates or the BJP. Ministers and leaders of the ruling party vilified the protesters, administrations under their control harassed and detained agitators, and right-wing activists continue to hound participants. Many right-wing outfits not only blame reservations for all of India's ills, but also are openly casteist. The government openly opposed same-sex unions in the Supreme Court, and a committee formed to look at civil rights for queer people has met only twice in three years, according to data presented in Parliament. HT has reported how examination reforms are slow to be implemented even as wider curricular changes remain bogged down in polarising ideological issues while doing little to improve the quality of education imparted. And, there appears to be little political support behind increasing budgetary spending on education.

Bhagwat attempted to strike a pose that was modern yet nationalist, pragmatic yet balanced. But putting in the hard yards will require the ruling coalition to have many such conversations internally, making sure that the message percolates down and catalyses changes in mindsets and actions. As Gen Z says, clock it.

{ MINOR HINTS }

Rahul Sagar

Cut the bull about Bitchat and State powers, Mr Dorsey

The government of India would be remiss if it did not prevent a technology from being deliberately deployed to frustrate law enforcement

In his famous essay, *On Bullshit*, philosopher Harry Frankfurt wrote that the "essence of bullshit" is a "phony" statement that is "disconnected from a concern with the truth". It comes from a person who simply does not care what is true or false but wants only to posture. Such hippnacy, Frankfurt argued, makes it "a greater enemy of the truth than lies are".

A notable sample of the same was served up by Jack Dorsey, the co-founder and former CEO of Twitter, who took to X to complain when, in the midst of a student protest in Central Delhi, the government ordered GitHub to block access to Bitchat, an app that he designed to allow users to communicate over a "mesh" of Bluetooth connections and thereby evade government control over and surveillance of internet channels.

Dorsey's post, now viewed nearly four million times, shared the blocking order and curtly declared that the Government of India "does not like technologies like Bitchat". The curtness is not new. In 2018, Dorsey posed with a placard that said "Smash Brahminical Patriarchy", signalling his deep knowledge of the millennia-old civilisation he was visiting for the first time (he visited the Dalai Lama too, but somehow omitted to carry a placard saying "Smash Serfdom"). Or consider Dorsey's bio on X, which simply reads "no state is the best state", a grand statement from an individual whose wealth and property are protected by the immense powers of the US.

Since Dorsey is evidently going to sloganeering, what should we think about the Indian government's order? Consider three criticisms.

It is possible to argue that peer-to-peer messaging apps like Bitchat — which free users from dependence on a network or server — should be permitted because they can prove useful when

outages or disasters affect internet service. This argument is not conclusive, however. The fact that a technology has legitimate emergency uses does not establish a right to deploy it during serious disturbances.

A second objection is that it is futile to try to control open-source technology. When GitHub was ordered to take down Bitchat, copies of its repository quickly appeared elsewhere, while downloads and usage reportedly increased, leading critics to gleefully cite it as an example of the Streisand Effect. This objection is unavailing. A sufficiently motivated government can employ technical countermeasures, impose requirements on devices sold in the country, and, in *extremis*, permit the inspection of phones. It is all very well to cosplay a Soviet dissident by talking up features such as Bitchat's "panic wipe" (where tapping three times on the app's icon erases its data), but such theatrics are unlikely to withstand determined threats.

A third objection is that the takedown order lacks statutory and constitutional support because it relies on Section 79(3)(b) of the Information Technology Act, which grants intermediaries (in this case, GitHub) immunity from prosecution so long as they remove content (in this case, Bitchat) that is deemed unlawful. According to critics such as the Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF), Section 79(3)(b) was never meant to be employed as "a blocking power" and using it to block an entire application — rather than a particular unlawful use of that application — violates Article 19(2) of the Constitution.

The statutory complaint stands on shaky ground. In its widely circulated commentary on the Bitchat order, the IFF omitted to mention a recent decision in *X v. Union of India* (2025), in which the Karnataka High Court upheld this use of Section 79(3)(b). The court relied in substantial measure on the argument that the blocking procedures authorised under Shreya Singhal v. Union of India (2015) — which require "a hearing and reasons recorded in writing, subject to review" — can stymie prompt intervention in an era when technological advances have vastly increased the scale and speed with which "unlawful content" can spread. It is certainly

India's march towards self-reliance in med-tech

India has witnessed unprecedented expansion of health care infrastructure over the last decade. A rapid increase in the numbers of hospitals in both the public and private sector, primary health centres, diagnostic centres and medical colleges in both urban and rural areas is a testament to Union government's citizen-centric policies on ensuring health security. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the government has worked to make quality health care accessible to every citizen. This untiring commitment has led to a significant reduction of out-of-pocket (OOP) expenditure on health care in the country, from as high as 65% to 43% in the last few years.

From a newborn in a district hospital to a cancer patient in a tertiary-care centre, reliable, high-quality yet affordable medical devices have become indispensable to modern health care. The government is strengthening public health systems in both rural and urban areas through investments in upgradation of laboratories, critical care infrastructure, disease surveillance systems, and emergency response mechanisms under Pradhan Mantri Aayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission (PM-AHBIM). As India advances towards VISION Bharat 2047, the focus is now on building an Atmanirbhar med-tech ecosystem to make health care more affordable, accessible and resilient.

Historically, India relied heavily on imports

for many sophisticated medical devices. While these technologies improved health care, they also contributed to higher costs, supply-chain vulnerabilities and limited accessibility. Recognising this, the National Medical Devices Policy 2019 set out a vision to build a self-reliant med-tech ecosystem.

Beyond enhancing domestic manufacturing capacity and capability for new technologies such as to make medical devices affordable and reduce diagnostics costs. The government adopted a comprehensive strategy to strengthen the medical devices ecosystem through initiatives such as the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme, Medical Device Parks, and the Promotion of Research and Innovation in Pharma-MedTech (PRIP) scheme. These initiatives are creating an enabling ecosystem for manufacturing, innovation, investment, and global competitiveness.

The results are encouraging. Manufacturing of more than 50 high-end medical devices has commenced under the PLI scheme. Equally significant is the growing confidence of global investors, reflected in sustained foreign direct investment in the sector. These achievements demonstrate that India is steadily emerging as a trusted partner in the global med-tech value chain.

India is also quickly adopting medical technol-

ogy advancements to improve the lives of citizens. Affordable access to advanced diagnostics, imaging systems, implants, intensive care equipment, and digital health solutions significantly reduce the financial burden on patients while improving the quality and timeliness of care. Domestic manufacturing contributes directly to this objective by reducing import dependence, strengthening supply-chain resilience and creating opportunities for cost efficiencies.

India's globally recognised pharmaceutical industry, robust engineering capabilities, rapidly expanding digital public infrastructure, vibrant start-up ecosystem, and skilled human resources provide a strong foundation for developing next-generation medical technologies. Emerging areas such as artificial intelligence (AI), software as a medical device (SaMD), connected medical devices, robotics, and remote diagnostics present opportunities for India to innovate for both domestic and global health care needs.

As Indian manufacturers expand globally, quality is also becoming the defining characteristic of Brand India med-tech. The government is focusing on strengthening regulatory systems, expanding accredited testing infrastructure, promoting clinical evidence generation, and aligning with international standards to enhance both patient safety and global competitiveness.

Building a globally competitive med-tech ecosystem also requires close collaboration among the government, industry, academia, health care providers, start-ups, and investors. Innovation flourishes when ideas meet seam-



When Jack Dorsey writes that the government of India does not "like" Bitchat, and when advocacy groups describe its takedown order as "authoritarian", they are insinuating that the government of India is acting illegitimately.

possible that, upon further review, courts will add or refine safeguards on the use of Section 79(3)(b). But, as a matter of principle, it is hard to see how they can disagree with justice M Nagaprassanna's observation that every State is entitled to exercise "timely and effective regulation" over speech and expression when important public interests are at stake. This brings us to the constitutional issue: Is it reasonable to block an entire application, specifically one that allows the circumvention of internet shutdowns? When Dorsey writes that the government of India does not "like" Bitchat, and when advocacy groups like IFF describe its takedown order as "authoritarian", they are insinuating that the government of India is acting illegitimately — that it is acting roughly or contrary to what the Constitution or citizens will permit.

As a matter of constitutional principle, this is nonsense. To safeguard citizens is an essential duty of the State. Hence the timeless doctrine, *salus populi suprema lex* (the safety of the people is the supreme law). Of course, safety is not the only interest in play. A constitutional regime seeks to shape how varied and often conflicting interests are to be balanced against one another. The constitutional imperative, per Article 12(2), that the government of India only impose "reasonable restrictions" on speech and expression is well established — and for good reason. The abuse of power is always a concern and citizens are certainly entitled to demand safeguards — and officers are correspondingly obliged to abide by such rules. But this does not mean the power in question should not exist. In the current context, the government of India would in fact be remiss if it did not prevent a technology

from being deliberately deployed to frustrate law enforcement. Courts may, of course, choose to ask for an *ex parte* showing as to the necessity of an internet shutdown — and why alternative, less draconian, measures will not suffice. But the suggestion that the State should be wholly debarred from employing shutdowns presumes there can be no public interest whatsoever in preventing subversive elements from taking advantage of a protest or disturbance.

This brings us to a deeper point about political legitimacy. It has become fashionable to belittle decisions of the government of India as mere expressions of "authoritarianism". Perhaps, it needs to be understood that the name of a sovereign people, whose democratically elected representatives and constitutionally mandated institutions give political and legal expression to their interests.

The preferences expressed through this arrangement may be noisy and disorderly, and our existing political system may translate them imperfectly into policy.

But, for all its flaws, this arrangement vests the government of India with far greater political legitimacy than that enjoyed by unelected individuals and advocacy groups that grandiloquently assume that everyone lacks — or ought to lack — their preferred policies. If Indians repeatedly vote for a law and order agenda, then that is their sovereign choice. And so, with all due respect, spare us the bull, Jack.

Rahul Sagar is a Global Network associate professor at NYU Abu Dhabi. His latest book is *The Birth of Indian Liberalism. The views expressed are personal*



Jagat Prakash Nadda

and global health care needs. As Indian manufacturers expand globally, quality is also becoming the defining characteristic of Brand India med-tech. The government is focusing on strengthening regulatory systems, expanding accredited testing infrastructure, promoting clinical evidence generation, and aligning with international standards to enhance both patient safety and global competitiveness.

Building a globally competitive med-tech ecosystem also requires close collaboration among the government, industry, academia, health care providers, start-ups, and investors. Innovation flourishes when ideas meet seam-

lessly from laboratories to manufacturing facilities and, finally, to patients. The government remains committed to providing a stable and transparent policy environment that encourages research, investment, technology partnerships and ease of doing business.

As India advances towards becoming a developed nation, health care and economic growth will increasingly reinforce each other. A strong medical devices sector creates high-value manufacturing, skilled employment, exports and technological capability while simultaneously making healthcare more affordable, accessible and resilient.

India's med-tech sector is the fourth-largest market in Asia and ranks among the top 20 globally. With a size of \$15.6 billion at present, the market is growing at almost 12% CAGR, making it one of the fastest-growing manufacturing sectors in the country. The vision of VISION Bharat stresses on building global leadership rooted in quality, innovation, and inclusivity. The government is working to ensure that technologies address India's public health priorities — from maternal and child health to non-communicable diseases, emergency care, cancer, cardiovascular diseases and rural health care delivery. India is steadily building an Atmanirbhar med-tech ecosystem that is not merely about manufacturing devices in India, but also about empowering every citizen with timely access to quality health care, strengthening health security, and positioning India as a trusted global partner in advancing better health for humanity.

Jagat Prakash Nadda is Union minister of health & family welfare and minister of chemicals & fertilizers. The views expressed are personal

Treating India's diabetes epidemic with GLP-1 drugs

India is facing a rare convergence of public health need, scientific progress, and economic opportunity. More than 100 million adults live with diabetes and another 136 million with pre-diabetes. At the same time, GLP-1 therapies, initially developed to control blood sugar, have demonstrated reductions in cardiovascular events, kidney disease and mortality in clinical trials. For appropriately selected patients, they represent an advance in preventing the complications that make diabetes so costly for families and the health system. The WHO's decision in 2025 to include GLP-1 therapies in its Essential Medicines List for high-risk people with type 2 diabetes reinforces the clinical case.

International obesity thresholds can miss many Indians with diabetes and cardiovascular disease at much lower body weights. Eligi-

ble, thus, must reflect South Asian physiology, and India's distinctive disease burden. Competition has reduced prices and could push them down further. But even a monthly cost of ₹1,300 or ₹1,500 is beyond the reach of most Indian households when treatment continues for years. Diabetes-related complications impose enormous treatment costs, reduce household income, push family members into caregiving and land vulnerable families in debt. The real comparison, thus, is between timely treatment and the larger future costs of preventable complications.

A carefully targeted programme could offer reasonable value for public spending. Available estimates remain provisional, requiring India to aggregate its own clinical and economic evidence before making a large national commitment. The country should begin with a controlled, phased access programme focused on people with type 2 diabetes who also have cardiovascular or kidney disease, and other high-risk groups. A four- or five-state pilot could test eligibility criteria, clinical protocols, procurement arrangements, safety, and cost-effectiveness. Expansion should depend on demonstrated outcomes, not commercial pressure.

Those covered under the programme will need gradual dose escalation, monitoring for adverse effects on advice on diet, physical activity. International experience shows high discontinuation rates, often because patients cannot manage side effects or afford continued treatment. Without strong follow-up, public expenditure will risk without producing the expected health gains. There must also be fire safeguards against inappropriate prescribing and cosmetic use.

Clear inclusion criteria, real-time pharmacovigilance and an independent safety board empowered to pause the programme should be built into India's med-tech manufacturing affordable versions of medicines discovered elsewhere. GLP-1 therapies offer an opportunity to go further — from manufacturer to innovator and generator of globally relevant evidence. The government needs to carry the entire early risk. Philanthropic and catalytic capital can finance India-specific trials, protocol development, affordability pilots, adherence systems and independent evaluation. Domestic manufacturers can contribute through competitive procurement and outcome-linked arrangements. The government must, however, retain stewardship of clinical standards, patient safety and data. Lifestyle changes, while important, alone cannot address the diabetes epidemic. The need is to expand access to GLP-1 therapies gradually, scaling only when results justify it.

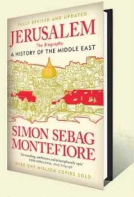
Indu Bhushan is a former IAS officer and founding CEO, National Health Authority. The views are personal

{ EDITOR'S PICK }

HT's editors offer a book recommendation every Saturday, which provides history, context, and helps understand recent news events

THE MANY JERUSALEMS

Jordan is convening a meeting of Arab and Islamic leaders to discuss the "imminent" takeover of sites of importance to Islam in Jerusalem, the declared capital of Israel and a locus of immense significance in world history as also of tearing disputes between the three Abrahamic faiths. A thorough detailing and analysis of claims, counter-claims and festering tensions over Jerusalem's religious citadels throughout history can be found in British historian Simon Sebag Montefiore's *The Biography*. Montefiore discusses how every conquest and occupation of Jerusalem razed old edifices, rival faiths and built upon their ruins — adding layers of contestations to the claims over its city and its sites. Histories of tyranny and revolt and the waxing and waning of Jewish, Muslim and Christian populations in the city are told with academic dispassion. As yet another wave of claimants tries to displace its rivals, the book offers insights into a "forever conflict".



Jerusalem: A Biography
Simon Montefiore
2011

INDIA-FCRA

FCRA would "permit government takeovers of churches and religious charities". He added, "This is a clear attack against Christians. If this bill proceeds in this way, it would be a point of major concern in our bilateral relationship with India."

Risch also said the US would not "hesitate to call out countries that violate the internationally recognised human rights of Christians and other religious groups around the world". The Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill 2026 has been introduced in Lok Sabha but is yet to be taken up for discussion. The bill states that when FCRA licenses aren't renewed, foreign contributions and assets of an entity will "provisionally" go to a "Designated Authority" notified by the government. It would also ensure a fresh registration within a prescribed period, the foreign contributions and assets will vest permanently with the authority, which will use it for public purposes.

Union home minister Amit Shah has met chief minister Lalitha of Mizoram, a Christian majority state, and representatives of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of India (CBCI) to discuss concerns about the proposed changes to FCRA and assured them that the proposed law will not apply retrospectively.

CBCI has expressed concerns that the proposed changes can "affect charitable institutions that have served poor and vulnerable communities for decades". It sought safeguards to ensure that existing rights, legally acquired assets and ongoing charitable activities are protected.

VIVEK VIHAR FIRE REPORT tionally, it blamed officials of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) for failing to detect fire violations during the construction.

Queries sent to Vardhaman Business Ventures Limited by HT via email did not elicit a response.

The fire – which killed nine people from three families and critically injured another – started after a probable short-circuit in the outdoor unit of an air-conditioner on the second floor.

It was part of a larger string

of accidents, building collapses and blazes – including the June 3 Haur Rani fire in which 23 people died, the July 8 Rohini Sector 16 twin building collapse (three dead), the May 30 collapse of a building in south Delhi's Saidulajab (six dead) and the March 18 fire at residential-cum-commercial building in Palam (nine dead) – that underscored poor monitoring, lax regulations and flagrant flouting of rules by multiple agencies and the police.

"The tragedy was considerably aggravated by multiple contributory factors including deficiencies in fire safety measures, restricted means of escape, the locked terrace access, inadequate ventilation, deviations from prescribed building safety norms, congested approach lanes affecting emergency access, and the rapid spread of smoke and flames within the building," said the report, which ran to over 400 pages.

"These factors collectively contributed to the loss of life and injuries sustained in the incident."

MCD officials did not respond to HT's attempts for a comment. A senior DPS official said that the agency will comment after seeing the report.

The inquiry said the building plan was sanctioned in 2013 after the original owner bought the plot from DDA. The authorised signatory of Delhi-based Vardhaman Business Ventures Limited told the panel that it acquired the already constructed property in February 2015 through share transfer documents and that construction was completed before the takeover.

But the report rejected the claim, noting that the company failed to produce any evidence to support its version.

"However, he could not provide any proof in support of his submission that these flats at address B-13, Phase-I, Vivek Vihar were already built in 2015 or the construction still continuing," the report said.

The inquiry questioned why the company never applied for an occupancy certificate after taking over the project, noting that it "could not provide any explanation for non-application of occupancy certificate".

"This company could not apply for the occupancy certificate and the flats at Plot No. B-13, Vivek Vihar were sold to differ-

ent persons without obtaining occupancy certificate from MCD."

Holding the builders accountable, the inquiry said, "The owners of the company... during the period 2013-18 are the prime culprits in this case against whom the appropriate legal action is required."

The inquiry found multiple violations of the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act, 1957, the Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL), 2016, and the National Building Code (NBC) of India, 2016. The DMC Act governs the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to manage civic administration, public health, and urban infrastructure in Delhi; UBBL are a comprehensive set of regulations governing the planning, design, construction, and safety standards for buildings in Delhi. They aim to ensure orderly urban development while incorporating provisions for structural safety, accessibility, environmental sustainability, and fire protection. NBC is a national instrument providing guidelines for regulating the building construction activities across the country. It mainly contains fire safety requirements, material quality, plumbing and structural design.

The report noted that although the online application seeking approval of the layout plan was filed on August 30, 2013, MCD was unable to produce the layout plan before the inquiry panel. MCD officials who appeared before the panel said no inspections were conducted by them following the sanctioning of building plans.

The report flagged multiple violations. Instead of a single dwelling unit approved for each floor, two flats were constructed on every level. Iron-grill extensions beyond the sanctioned building line were converted into usable floor space.

"Concluding, the inquiry panel, the inquiry panel from the sanctioned building plan by constructing two dwelling units/flats at each floor instead of the sanctioned building plan, constitute deviations from the sanctioned building configuration and are prima facie inconsistent with the provisions of the Unified Building Bye-Laws for Delhi, 2016," the report said.

"The legality of these deviations, including their conform-

ity with the sanctioned building plan, requires examination by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi for taking appropriate action in accordance with law."

The inquiry concluded that while an electrical short circuit may have sparked the blaze, it was the cumulative effect of regulatory violations, unauthorised construction, blocked escape routes and inadequate fire safety measures that turned it into a major tragedy.

The inquiry also flagged shortcomings in the emergency response, noting that the first distress call was routed to Uttar Pradesh before being transferred to Delhi. It said DPS initially dispatched a fire tender, but its water tanker ran dry within five minutes, forcing personnel at the site to seek additional vehicles.

The magisterial inquiry reports into the Haur Rani fire, Saidulajab building collapse and the Palam fire had also indicted the MCD and other agencies for failing to enforce norms.

In the May Saidulajab building collapse, the magisterial probe found MCD officials didn't monitor or crackdown on illegal construction, sat on multiple complaints, failed to enforce norms and later fabricated retrospective inspection records to mislead investigators. In the Haur Rani fire, the report said agencies allowed an illegally expanded building to continue operating as a bed-and-breakfast despite repeated warnings. The magisterial probe report into the March 18 Palam fire had also raised concerns about fire safety, the unpreparedness of agencies to tackle emergencies and the brittle backbone of Delhi's civic systems.

HEAVY RAIN IN NCR month of August.

Two people died in a building collapse in Gurugram. In Delhi, around 90 complaints of wall collapse, fallen trees, power outages and waterlogging were filed by the authorities. From the Mehrauli-Badarpur Road in south Delhi to Mahipalpur, ITO, Shakarpur and Chhatrapur, commuters were trapped in traffic for hours, motorists abandoned flooded stretches and office-goers struggled to book cabs.

Some of the worst flooding was reported on the Mehrauli-

Badarpur (MB) Road. Water entered Safdarjung Hospital and the entrance of the Greater Kailash metro station, Kapashera near the IGI airport resembled a river, water sloshed around pavements in Greater Kailash 2 and entered the Jahapana urban forest, and residents struggled to wade through puddles in Okhla, Sadar Bazaar, Mahipalpur and Saket.

"The city gets flooded every year. This is due to poor sewage and drainage infrastructure," said BK Dutt, 62, a resident of Barari.

Visuals from Chhatrapur showed school students wading through knee-deep water as vehicles crawled along submerged stretches of the MB Road. In Sangam Vihar, visuals showed residents pushing vehicles in waist-deep water while people on two-wheelers were stranded.

Chaos also unfolded in the Capital's neighbouring region. In Gurugram, heavy rain inundated major parts of the city for the third consecutive day on Friday, crippling traffic on key arterial roads, flooding public facilities, as civic agencies scrambled to deploy pumps and clear water. The scale of disruption once again laid bare the city's vulnerability to rain, with roads, underpasses, drains and even recently built infrastructure struggling to cope with the downpour. According to IMD, Gurugram recorded 172mm of rainfall in the 72 hours till Friday, including 60mm till 5.30pm.

Several parts of Noida and Greater Noida also witnessed mess of flooded roads, submerged underpasses and snarling traffic. According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the Noida region recorded 39mm of rainfall in the 24 hours ending at 8.30am on Friday.

In Delhi, traffic crawled for kilometres between Khanpur and Okhla Mor, while adjoining stretches at Sangam Vihar, Deoli and Ambekar Nagar also remained inundated. In Fatehpur Beri's Valmiki Basti, residents waded through waist-deep water while schoolchildren, unable to cross flooded lanes, were carried by locals on a large blue plastic sheet used as a makeshift raft.

Rameshwari Devi, 39, who works as a domestic help and

lives in Begumpur was stuck in traffic for at least two hours near Chirag Dilli, barely 3 km from her home. "Even ambulances were stuck. What usually takes me an hour to get to work took me at least three today. When I returned home, I realised my lane and my house were flooded."

Traffic moved at snail's pace on Sardar Patel Marg, Teen Murti Marg, Fanchsheel Marg, Mother Teresa Crescent, around the Gol Dak Khana roundabout, Rafi Marg, Ashoka Road, C-Hex, and around ITO.

In the southern parts of the city, heavy traffic choked multiple places on the Ring Road between Dhaulika Kuan and Indraprastha flyover via Ashram Chowk, Delhi-Gurgaon national highway-48 via Mahipalpur, and Mathura Road between Badarpur and Ashram Chowk.

Sangam Vihar, Durga Vihar and Deoli-Khanpur were among the worst-hit areas, with roads flooded with rainwater and traffic movement severely disrupted.

"Despite everyone being aware that waterlogging is an annual problem, our complaints over multiple years have fallen on deaf ears. Today again it has been a very big problem, with multiple main and arterial roads waterlogged. Additionally, due to the rain, multiple trees got uprooted and fell during the day," said Anantamala Podar, Saket D61 to D125 Resident Welfare Association (RWA) president.

The Pushp Vihar station of the India Meteorological Department (IMD) recorded the highest rainfall at 147.5 mm, from 8.30 am to 8.30 pm, followed by Chhatrapur (131 mm), Palam (88.7 mm), and Anayagar (87.4 mm), all of which would qualify as different degrees of heavy rain – the category IMD assigns to rain of more than 35.3 mm for a 24-hour period. Safdarjung is also all set to record the rainiest first eight days of August since 2011, the first year for which Safdarjung's data is publicly available from IMD. The total up to 05:30pm on August 7 is already higher than the previous record of 135 mm rain up to 08:30am on August 8 held by 2024.

IMD records rain for a date as the rainfall up to 08:30am on the date. The August 1-7 period, which includes rain from 08:30

am on July 31 to 08:30 am on August 7, is also the rainiest this year since 2011. To be sure, most of the rain of the first week fell only starting August 5. This makes the total rain in the four-day period ending 08:30am on August 8 the rainiest four-day period this monsoon.

"The widespread rainfall over Delhi since yesterday has been influenced by the active monsoon trough, which continues to pass through Delhi and other parts of north and east India before extending into the east-central Bay of Bengal. Rainfall activity over Delhi is expected to decrease from tomorrow, with light rain likely over the city during the next two days," an IMD official said.

The widespread chaos sparked angry responses from residents, many of whom blamed choked drains, poorly designed roads and inaction by authorities.

Ashok Singh, a resident of Sunlight Colony, said "Our area has witnessed waterlogging for two days now, and the water seeped into my car and my house today. Power cuts worsened the situation."

But public works department minister Parvash Verma said waterlogging in the city's major hotspots was resolved, adding that inundation was reported mainly in some villages and rural areas where drainage projects were still in progress.

"The rain is the same, but the preparation has changed, and that's why, today, monsoon in Delhi no longer means waterlogging, but is becoming synonymous with better management," he posted on X, along with visuals of Minto Bridge, Vinod Nagar, Jhilimil Underpass, among others.

(With inputs from Mihika Shah and Sampurna Pantgrahi in Gurugram, Maria Khan in Noida)

U.S. TARIFFS BILL

last hurdle before it reaches President Donald Trump for signature. Trump, whose officials helped shape the softened text now before Congress, has signalled support for House passage.

Today, President Zelenskyy is watching from Ukraine – and Putin is watching from Moscow," Senator Richard Blumenthal, a Connecticut Democrat who worked with Graham on

the package, said on the Senate floor. "I would like to think Lindsey Graham is watching, too. Today we say to the people of Ukraine: You are not alone. And today we say to Vladimir Putin: You will not conquer Ukraine."

For India, the vote comes as it and the US are attempting to hammer out a trade deal. It potentially offers Washington another lever over New Delhi even as the first – the Section 301 forced-labour tariff imposed last month, and the excess-capacity investigation still open – reshapes the arithmetic on which those talks proceed.

To be sure, Washington itself has tolerated purchases of Russian crude when it waived sanctions to ease an energy crisis its own actions in West Asia had created following the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz. That waiver has since expired.

The bill's mechanism gives both governments room. The USTR rate-setting discretion is the first pressure point: an executive branch that was involved in drafting the softening can, if it chooses, set the rate below the 100% ceiling, or invoke the presidential waiver on certified national interest grounds. Reassessment every 180 days keeps the instrument reversible.

Indian negotiators have pressed their American counterparts to offer New Delhi a competitive advantage to its trade rivals, such as Bangladesh and Indonesia.



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Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



PARAMITA SEN
AUTHOR, *BATANAGAR: A
PERSONAL HISTORY OF INDIA'S
FORGOTTEN COMPANY TOWN*

No one stepped up
to preserve the
township, which
has so much
history.

On the Books &
Authors podcast



PABLO CARTAYA | AUTHOR OF
BOOKS FOR CHILDREN, YOUNG ADULTS

'I cannot
help being an
optimist'

At the Neev Literature Festival, the
Cuban-American writer speaks about
family, and helping children feel safe

Chintan Girish Modi

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1 Your latest novel, *A Hero's Guide to Summer Vacation*, is built around the relationship between a man and his grandson on a road trip in the US. What led to this idea?

One day, while looking back at my work, I realised that I have grandmothers in all my books, who are all versions of my own *abuela*. But I hadn't done a grandfather book until then, and I wanted to change that. That's how Alberto William Garcia, the grandfather in my book *A Hero's Guide to Summer Vacation*, was born.

Alberto is an author who writes fantasy for children, so I thought it would be fun to send him on a book tour with his 13-year-old grandson Gonzalo Alberto Sánchez Garcia, and explore their relationship.

He comes across as grumpy at first. But once you get past that facade, you see that he is a gentle, sweet man. Their cross-country road trip starts in Mendocino and ends in Miami.

I thought a lot about my own *abuelo*, my father's father, and my Cuban heritage, while working on this book. It was not easy to write, but each draft gave me clarity and confidence.

2 Tell me more about your *abuela*, and the characters she inspired you to write.

She died when I was just eight years old, so she is in all my books. Writing her into them is my way of keeping her alive. Whether it is the restaurant owner in *The Epic Fall of Arturo Zamora*, the farmer in *The Last Beekeeper*, or the businessman in *Curveball*, there is a bit of her in all of them.

When I visit schools, I encourage children to interview their grandparents. There is so much to learn from their memories and their struggles.

3 How do you see your role in the current political environment, with *homo* on the minds of children's books and young-adult literature becoming increasingly common in the US?

This issue is close to me, and it really breaks my heart. I am very fortunate that I get to speak all over the country and interact with young people, especially LGBTQ+ kids. They like to come and talk with me because I guess they feel safe. Some want to sign a book. But most of them just want to hang out and take pictures. And I say this to not pat my own back.

As a father, I feel very emotional when I meet kids who feel afraid to be themselves and then find one adult who feels somewhat safe. It hurts to witness that.

But it is also a privilege to be that person. Looking at the current political climate in the US, I worry about LGBTQ+ kids, but I cannot help being an optimist either.

I don't like bullies. And I believe in love more than hate.

There are days when I feel terrible about how things are. And then I allow myself to cry.



FOLKTALES | ABOUT THE BIRDS OF UTTARAKHAND

Off forktails, flycatchers and pheasants

Akanksha Abismruta
letters@hindustantimes.com

Birds have long been metaphors for the human desire for freedom. Phrases such as "free birds", "clipped wings" and "caged" indicate our yearning for the unhindered life. To fly is to move in any direction, to escape the mundane.

Neha Negi's *When Birds Talked* describes the primal desire "to be free and untethered, to soar through vast spaces without the weight of gravity." In this collection of 10 folktales about the birds of Uttarakhand, the author also looks at the roles of birds in myths from around the world, from Jatayu in the *Ramayana* to Vulcan's eagle in

Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, to trace the shared themes of death, resurrection, transformation and freedom. Each story is titled after a bird from the Himalayan state: Verditer Flycatcher, Green-Backed Tit, Spotted Forktail, Fir-Capped Tit, Himalayan Monal, Wedge-Tailed Green Pigeon, Blue Whistling Thrush, Asian Paradise Flycatcher, Black-Throated Tit, Kali Pheasant.

Labelled "imagined freestyle tales", each of these parables reads like they are meant to be shared by the hearth, with children and adults alike surrounding the storyteller.

Negi keeps her stories simple and straightforward. The characters are in their youth, which makes them the perfect vessels for life lessons on courage and honesty. Elements of magic

appear, often in the form of local deities of Uttarakhand such as Chanda Mahasu, Surasa Maatri and Aanchi. Adding to the general sense of wonder are the author's vibrant hand-painted illustrations of village landscapes, forests, human characters and birds.

Inspired by folklore, these tales entice readers to suspend disbelief and enter into a curious state where they accept magical elements as an active part of the surroundings. So, Duddhari descends from the skies and into the forest to be with a human whom she cannot talk to; a princess

becomes the woodwife of an old oak tree and lives in its shade; and a forest fairy steals fire to drive early humans out of the forest to maintain its ecological balance. Sometimes, humans turn into birds as a reward for their sacrifice; at other times, a new species of bird comes into being as a reward for a lone bird's determination and hard work.

When humans and birds consider themselves too smart to live with their kind, they are taught a lesson that, clearly, shared a nurturing connection—all of it make this a

brings into her tales. Good storytelling has the power to introduce readers to specific subjects without being burdened by adherence to fact. Stories may not provide all the data but they show the reader why something matters. Negi draws the reader's attention to the rich diversity of the Himalayas, home to more than 150 endemic bird species.

Rampant tourism has led to the birth of plastic litter in the mountains; "development" has led hydroelectric projects to submerge tracts of forest. All this coupled with climate change has led to a steady decline in the bird populations of the region. In this era of the Anthropocene, because the crisis is huge, a sense of helplessness sets in even at the local level, with people often starting

to believe that they are insignificant and can do nothing to make a difference.

In such a scenario, books such as *When Birds Talked* rebuild the reader's connection with nature. Even if such stories don't lead to immediate change, there is a chance they will encourage readers to wonder, as WH Davies does in his poem *Let-sure*, why they no longer have the "time to stand and stare."

This, in turn, might lead them to join a birding group or pay more attention to the sights and sounds of local avian life.

Indeed, Negi's stories encourage all who read them to reflect on humanity's relationship with nature. The world might face a climate crisis, but there is still a chance to preserve the varied life and remaining forests on this blue dot we call home. *When Birds Talked* is a timely reminder of this possibility.

Akanksha Abismruta is an independent writer

517 years since Krishnadevaraya became emperor of Vijayanagara



One of the greatest rulers in Indian history, Krishnadevaraya (January 17, 1471–October 17, 1529) became emperor of the Vijayanagara Empire in 1509. During his 20-year rule, the empire reached its apogee and included what are now the modern states of Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Goa and Tamil Nadu as well as parts of Odisha, Telengana, Maharashtra and Kerala. Above, statues of Krishnadevaraya and his wives at the Chandragiri archaeological museum in Hampi Pradesh. At left, the Virupaksha Temple in Hampi that was rebuilt for Krishnadevaraya's coronation.

BATHNAGA/ANAND REDDY/WIREIMAGE; VMUTHIRAMAN/GETTY IMAGES

POETRY PICK

DAKHNI REFUSES RETIREMENT

Every few decades someone declares me endangered. Linguists become concerned. Bureaucrats become sentimental. Cultural organizations organize conferences. I continue surviving without assistance. The problem is that scholars mistake language for grammar. Language is not grammar. Language is gossip. Language is flirtation. Language is bargaining. Language is insult. Language is affection disguised as insult. Language is the tea seller asking where you vanished. Language is the auto driver explaining politics. Language is the grandmother selling, unnamed pickle and appadalu, in Telugu! I have survived empires, nationalism, modernization, television, and English-medium schools. I will probably survive the conferences too.

Intimate yet philosophical, the poems in *Tea and Tombs: Poems on Hyderabad* serves as both a tribute to that city and reflections on belonging, time, and place.

Tea and Tombs: Poems on Hyderabad
Manu S Kurup
112pp, ₹450, Hawaki

HT PICKS | NEW READS

THE TURBULENT PASTS OF INDIA'S HEARTLAND

Shantanu Nandan Sharma's *Red Bastar* asks some deep questions about contemporary India: How did ideological extremism embed itself so deeply within tight-knit indigenous societies? What does the history of Bastar tell us about governance, land rights and developmental failures?

In March this year, the government of India declared the Maoist insurgency effectively defeated. A question still lingers: Why did the ideology find haven here for over four decades?

Drawing on years of ground reporting, Sharma traces Bastar's turbulent past, from human sacrifices in Dantewada and British incursions into its forests for teak and minerals, to a beloved prince's rebellion and the gradual rise of Naxal influence.

Rich in historical insight, this book is essential reading for anyone seeking to understand internal security, democracy and dissent in modern India.

Red Bastar
Shantanu Nandan Sharma
313pp, ₹799, Hachette India

A SLAVE TURNS HERO

Amid a war on a disputed planet, a woman is thrust into battle. The slave-turned-reliant hero must now fight to uncover the truth about her identity. Bora Chung's novel draws on the history of Korean soldiers who died in a war against Russia on behalf of China's Qing Dynasty. *Red Sword* combines stunning world-building with a thought-provoking question to readers: What does it really mean to wield power?

Red Sword
Bora Chung. Translated by Anton Hur
183pp, ₹319, Pan Macmillan

on the web

READ: Bhutan blends Sudeep Sen's sharp, reflective poetry and photography with Ravi Shankar's analytical prose, which questions his Western perspective on the Himalayan nation's complexities. The photographs, with their rich cultural texture, add to it all by highlighting both sacred and everyday scenes.

Scan the QR code to read the review by Jhilam Chattaraj



A close-up view of the Himalayan monal.

SHUTTERSTOCK



When Birds Talked
Neha Negi
192pp, ₹599, Penguin

RELAX. THE WEEKEND'S HERE

brunch

column { rude food }

Just follow the crunch



VIR SANGHVI

So far there has only been one really delicious Indian fried chicken sandwich: The Rowdy Rooster in New York created by Chintan Pandya. If Chintan can do it so successfully in New York then surely chefs in India should be able to follow his lead?

Kritika Kapoor
kritika.kapoor@hindustantimes.com

crushes work like demand-pull inflation

Maahvika Bhat (@MaahvikaBhat) who's working towards a PhD in Computer Science and Communication at Northwestern University in the U.S, has been making other geeky connections. "Pop culture is often dismissed as frivolous, but it can be very revealing of our moral preoccupations," Bhat says. In her Reels, she talks race, feminist theory and Dilip Dosanjh. She looks at how White women temper their appreciation of the conventionally attractive man with a tinge of embarrassment. That, Bhat says, is "so revealing of their anxieties about who they might be attracted to." It's the kind of racism that casual observers would miss.

In theory

In one Reel, Bhat brings in Pull and Demand Inflation to explain why you might be crushing on someone: During inflation, "things aren't getting better, but their price keeps increasing". Similarly, at moments of personal flux, your "flood of unspent attention" is likely to be poured into the nearest person, not necessarily the best one. It's the kind of relationship advice that makes more

Filming this

The Tangled live-action film is being shot in Spain. And everyone in the country has decided it's their mission to leak BTS clips online. We've seen Teagan Croft getting her hair braided by little girls. We've seen a puppet Maximus face-off with a mustachioed Milo Manheim. There are even vids of the reunion with the king and queen of Corona. Wait, there are live action leak accounts posting spoilers? At this point, release the whole movie on Reels.



Urvasi Rautela

The academics keep busy – there's enough happening in politics and pop culture every day to fuel 30-second Reels. Last month's protests calling for the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan gave Padmakshi Sharma, a former legal journalist and independent researcher, a great opportunity for a tutorial (@PadmakshiSh). Her video, How to Read Like an Artist, helped viewers see the undercurrents of how the protests were playing out in the media: "Focus on the adjectives," she told her 93.6K followers. "Is it a legal protest or an illegal protest? Is it a moving speech or an anti-national speech? Is there any evidence to back the adjective? The comments are filled with viewers thanking her for giving them tools to read the news critically."

Do the honours

Other academics merely decide what you didn't notice in mass-market shows. Nihal Singh Majithia's (@NihalSinghMajithia) reviews of the 2024 fantasy drama *Suhagan* and *Chudail* is one of Instagram's unlikely hits. The show has dodgy CGI and a witch who hunts husbands to stay young. But Majithia, who studied art and history, approaches it the way he would a classic by Nolan or Kurosawa. When the chudail's black cat is neutralised by a cloud of vermilion, he points out, it's a reference to the use of magic and power. He picks up on the show's redeemable qualities. "Even the chudail has agency to make decisions, to progress in her life and her career as a witch," he says. Some reels have 1.8 million views.

Sanjana Manakata, national initiatives and policy lead at the ed-tech non-profit Rocket Learning, follows a bunch of geeky pop culture accounts. She says that academics like Bhat and Subramanian "make cultural theory visible to people who otherwise might never encounter it" and "refuse to believe that what's happening around us is 'not that deep.' The lessons are useful." "We apply the same critical thinking we use to solve a maths or physics problem to the way human beings relate to one another, that's essentially what pop-culture analysis is. It helps us understand ourselves. It will only become more important as AI becomes a bigger part of our lives."

Feeling

Inspired
London's Royal Academy of Art is back with its summer kids' showcase, and we're revising our list of fav artists, immediately. Jake, aged 11, created the Peaaaaa Man—a surreal, grotesque clay impression of the melancholy you feel when your mum tells you to finish your peas. Liza, aged 5, drew a Sunset Pigeon contemplating its existence at sundown. There are six-legged unicorns and stinky cheese skies, snails brushing teeth and chips getting married. Art is hard to understand. But this makes so much sense.

Saving 'yes'

Jennifer Winget just tied the knot with William Ishmael in Wales. The best part of her look? Her wedding veil, which had the names of Winget's dogs, Oliver and Brezzer, embroidered on it. That's the kind of personalised detail we can get behind. It's sweet, heartfelt and so much cooler than hiding your partner's name in your mehendi.

WANT TO READ MORE?

Check out the second page of HT Brunch in the epaper. And dive into stories about life, love, good times and good vibes in the digital magazine, out every Saturday. We're also on hindustantimes.com/lifestyle/brunch, and the HT app (it's free!)



 **READ** the e-mag [here!](#)

HOT brunch BRUNCH AND BROADWAY IN A NEW

Pop theory

Carnival for the ultimate pop-culture junkies. Bring for the crowd-pleasing original pop-culture trivia game, featuring a variety of pop-culture questions. Includes a special "Pop Theory" trivia game, featuring a variety of pop-culture questions. Includes a special "Pop Theory" trivia game, featuring a variety of pop-culture questions.

Pop Theory is a fun and fast-paced trivia game that is sure to keep you entertained. It's a great way to test your pop-culture knowledge and win some cash.

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**This
week
we're**

Veto-ing Leto

Ten women have accused Jared Leto of sexual misconduct and assault in the new BBC documentary, *Jared Leto: Hollywood's Dark Secret*. We're not surprised. For years, there have been rumours of Leto pursuing underage girls. Also, remember when he started a cult? And the time he mailed his *Suicide Squad* co-stars rats and used condoms as 'gifts'? The only real surprise is that he still has an agent.

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READ the e-mag here!

HT
US court orders halt to Prez Trump's \$400mn WH project
WASHINGTON: A federal appeals court on Friday ordered the Trump administration to halt construction of its \$400 million ballroom at the White House (WH) without congressional approval. **AP**

China confirms first deaths in SCS clash in decades
BEIJING: China has posthumously honoured two Coast Guard officers who died while "safeguarding maritime rights" in the South China Sea (SCS) in August 2025, appearing to confirm the first Chinese fatalities from a clash with a Philippine Coast Guard ship in the contested waters since a collision with a US aircraft in 2001. **BLOOMBERG**

SpaceX, Tesla to build \$16.8bn chip plant in Texas
HOUSTON: SpaceX and Tesla are investing \$16.8 billion to build "Terafab", an advanced AI semiconductor complex in Texas, designed to narrow a looming gap in global chip supply, according to official statements. **PTI**

Saudi, Turkey, Pak tighten def alliance

Associated Press
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ANKARA, TURKEY: Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan signed a defence agreement on Friday that would treat an attack on one as an attack on all three, officials said, solidifying cooperation between the three regional powers at a time of growing security concerns. The agreement was signed in the Saudi holy city of Mecca by Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, according to statements from all three countries.

The agreement between the three Sunni Muslim-majority states brings together oil-rich Saudi Arabia and nuclear power Pakistan as well as Turkey, which has NATO's second-largest army and a rapidly growing defence industry. It would increase cooperation and deterrence at a time of increased regional uncertainty and threats from the war in Iran. "The agreement is intended to strengthen collective deterrence against any act of aggression, and stipulates that any armed attack against any one of the three states shall be regarded as an attack against them all," the statements read. "It further provides for the enhancement of all aspects of



Turkish President Tayyip Erdogan shakes hands with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman as Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif looks on in Mecca, Saudi Arabia, on Friday. **REUTERS**

defence cooperation among the three States," the statements said, adding that the agreement was called the "Mecca Joint Defence Agreement".

Saudi Arabia, whose critical infrastructure and oil facilities have come under attack as part of the war in Iran, has been looking to diversify its defence partnerships. In September last year, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia signed a mutual defence pact that also defines an attack on either nation as an attack on both. The agreement also comes amid rising tensions between Turkey and Israel over Gaza and other regional conflicts, including the war in Iran and Lebanon.

The deal highlights how far relations between Saudi Arabia and Turkey have shifted towards

alignment and partnership, after being highly strained just a few years ago, including over the killing of Saudi Arabian journalist Jamal Khashoggi in Istanbul by Saudi operatives.

Iran criticises def deal
In Iran, Ebrahim Rezaei, a member of the Iranian Parliament's National Security and Foreign Policy Commission, criticised the deal on X, saying it would not bring security to Saudi Arabia. "The Saudis should know that a paper agreement with Turkey and Pakistan will not bring them security, just as years of one-sided 'milling' by the Americans did not bring them security. Change your policies so that you do not have to flee for security from others," he wrote.

Check 737 Max for cracks, FAA tells airlines

Bloomberg
letters@hindustantimes.com
WASHINGTON: The US aviation regulator has asked operators of 471 Boeing Co. 737 Max jets to undertake checks for cracks of a component that could undermine the structural integrity of the aircraft. The affected area impacts a component that structurally reinforces the front-door frame

on some 737 planes, Boeing said. It requires an inspection of the fuselage panneling, according to the airworthiness directive. The Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) said the directive, posted on Thursday, would apply from September 10. The checks apply to in-service models of the new-generation Max jet including the 8, 9 and 8200 variants. "The FAA is issuing this AD

to address the unsafe condition on these products," the agency said, adding that the cracks could lead to the structural integrity of part of the plane to be "adversely" compromised. Boeing said it has been working with airline customers over the past six years after identifying the issue. It says the FAA-mandated checks stem from similar inspections for older generation 737NG jets in 2021.

"The FAA Airworthiness Directive published today mandates the inspections, as it did for the 737 Next Generation," a Boeing spokeswoman said in a statement. "We support both directives and continue to support our airline customers." The US plane maker said it has already conducted an engineering analysis and is working through changes to prevent future cracking.

Teen kills 7 in Thai shooting

AFP & Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

NONTHABURI, THAILAND: A 14-year-old boy in Thailand, described as "troubled" and "bullied" by a classmate, killed his grandparents before shooting dead five more people at a school on Friday, police said.

First he shot dead his two grandparents, using his grandfather's handgun, then went to a secondary school in Nonthaburi province, bordering Bangkok, and killed five school staff, national police said in a statement. Those killed at the school were all teachers and staff, and police said the shooter fired at least 26 bullets using a gun that belonged to his grandfather. An additional 34 rounds were found.

The 14-year-old perpetrator also died, the statement said, with a police official telling he had killed himself. Officials earlier gave a higher toll of eight dead, which had included the suspect, and initially said students were among the victims. Dozens of police and emergency responders gathered outside the cordoned-off Debsirin Nonthaburi School, AFP journalists saw, while parents waited to pick up their children and fearful students and staff comforted each other outside.

Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul told reporters at the scene that "police interrogated his close friend who said the suspect had been under stress" related to his schooling. "His actions also suggested that he had clearly planned" the



The body of a shooting victim is being carried out of the school premises north of Bangkok; a gun (top right), magazine and bullets found at the site of the shooting incident on Friday. **AFP, REUTERS**

assault, Anutin added. "The gun was a registered firearm and was kept at a home, but somehow he gained access to it." The prime minister said more than 30 people were injured, with around nine in critical condition. The shooter was identified by local media as a student of the school. Purin Khumchoo, 17, said he was among the students who had nearly been shot. "He was my junior, but I had a feeling that he was a troubled kid."

My group of friends who knew him said he was interested in the FBI and guns, and that he was bullied by many other students," Purin told AFP outside his school. "When I saw him aiming the gun at me, I thought he looked very professional, as if he had been trained for a long time." Photos published by local media show the suspect wearing a purple school uniform and carrying a black cross-body bag, with several bullet casings visible on the ground.

'PUBLIC NUISANCE': META ORDERED TO PAY \$567MM IN U.S. OVER CHILD HARM
SAN FRANCISCO: A US state court has ordered Meta to pay \$567 million and limit some features for children on its Facebook and Instagram platforms, saying the social media giant had created a "public nuisance" that endangered young users. The ruling in New Mexico on Thursday adds to a previous fine of \$375 million in the same case in March, when a jury found the social media giant liable for making youths vulnerable to predators on its platforms. "Today's decision is a victory for every parent who has worried about what social media is doing to their child and every child who deserves to grow up safer online," New Mexico Attorney General Raul Torrez said. **AFP**

US president tries to curb birthright citizenship despite top court ruling

Bloomberg
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump signed a pair of executive orders aimed at denying citizenship to certain people born in the US, his second attempt to curb birthright citizenship after the Supreme Court knocked down an earlier directive.

Under one measure signed on Thursday, mothers deemed to be seeking entry to the US for the sole purpose of having a child in the country, a practice known as "birth tourism", may be denied visas, barred for entering or removed upon arrival.

The other directs agencies to refrain from granting citizenship to those born to people deemed to be alien enemies, foreign terrorists and foreigners employed by diplo-

matic outposts or international organisations. Babies born in US territories could potentially be barred from gaining citizenship if Congress passes a law to that effect.

"We had a very unfortunate decision in the Supreme Court concerning birthright," Trump told reporters during an Oval Office signing. "So we're making adjustments because it's very unfair."

The orders are almost certain to be challenged in court as a violation of the 14th Amendment of the US Constitution, which guarantees citizenship to nearly everyone born in the country.

The top court in June struck down a sweeping executive order seeking to overturn the policy that Trump signed during the first day of his second term.

'THINK WAR WITH IRAN WILL END PRETTY SOON'
WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Thursday told reporters that he believed the war with Iran would be over soon and said the armed forces were experiencing issues with supplies of some weapons.

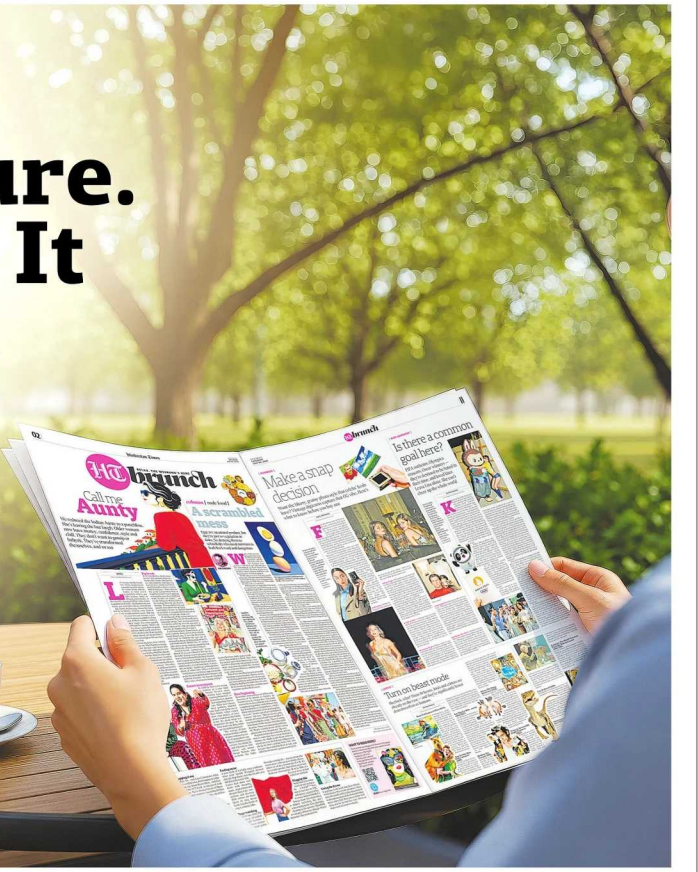
"I think it's going to end pretty soon. I don't think they [Iran] can go much longer," Trump said in the Oval Office. Trump, who stepped back from his most recent threats to resume military attacks on the Islamic Republic, said that the US is involved in negotiations, but declined to say whether an agreement had been reached. **REUTERS & BLOOMBERG**

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending. It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.

HT RELAX. THE WEEKEND'S HERE
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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



10 eyes \$10 billion FCNR(B) deposits

Chairman Setty said the bank did not have a mobilisation target

Anshika Kayastha
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MUMBAI: State Bank of India (SBI) has mobilised about \$6 billion in deposits under the Reserve Bank of India's special foreign currency non-resident (FCNR(B)) deposit window and expects to raise about \$10 billion (close to ₹1 lakh crore), chairman C.S. Setty said on Friday.

Speaking after the bank announced its first-quarter results, Setty said SBI did not have a specific mobilisation target, but the additional funds would help finance loan growth while reducing reliance on expensive bulk deposits.

Calling the liquidity from FCNR(B) deposits a "good, positive development", Setty pointed out that large banks stand to benefit more from these flows.

"Everyone will try to see that the bulk deposits are priced reasonably, if not completely removed out of bulk deposits. Essentially, as long as these flows are adequate to cover credit growth, SBI will not be aggressively pricing the bulk deposits," he said.

Setty added that an inflow of around ₹1 lakh crore does not materially "move the needle" on the bank's ₹60 lakh crore deposit base and will help fund incremental loan growth. "I do not think deploying ₹1 lakh crore (trillion) is a problem for SBI where we are looking at 15% credit growth, which means in around a year, we will be growing ₹5-6 lakh crore," he said.

The RBI has allowed banks to extend leverage against FCNR(B) deposits, enabling overseas depositors to reinvest the proceeds for potentially higher returns. Several lenders have offered leverage of 9-10



State Bank of India Chairman CS Setty addresses a press conference to announce the bank's Q1 results for FY27.

times, while some foreign banks have gone higher to attract inflows. Mint reported on 16 July.

Setty said SBI has largely been providing leverage through its own overseas branches, particularly its GIFT City branch, instead of tying up with foreign banks. The lender is also extending the use of standby letters of credit (SBLCs) to extend such leverage. "We have an SBLC bank product also, but it's not widely used at this moment," he said.

Asked whether the large FCNR(B) inflows would dilute net interest margins (NIM), as some private-sector lenders have indicated they could, Setty said it was too early to assess the impact because lower funding costs could offset any pressure on margins. "We are sticking to our guidance of 3% NIM for the full year and RoA (return on assets) of 1% and RoE (return on equity) of about 15%," he said.

SBI reported NIM of 2.86% in the June quarter, up five basis points sequentially. RoA stood at 1.1%, RoE was 17.87%.

On Friday, India's largest bank reported a 10.2% year-on-year (y-o-y) rise in net profit to ₹2,121 crore for the April-June quarter and a 14.9% rise in net

interest income (NII) to ₹46,992 crore.

Following the results, shares of the bank jumped 3.6% to ₹1,245 on the NSE, but later pared some gains to close 1.1% higher at ₹1,097.20. Comparatively, the Nifty Bank index ended 0.55% lower today at 57,746.45. Setty pegged overall deposit growth for the year at 10-11%.

In the first quarter, total deposits of the bank grew 9.73% y-o-y and 0.5% sequentially to ₹60.1 trillion.

On the other hand, credit growth for FY27 is seen at 14-15%, slower than the over 18% growth seen in Q1. Gross advances rose 18.6% y-o-y to ₹50.5 lakh crore as of 30 June.

On the wide gap between the pace of loan and deposit growth at the bank, Setty said: "With our excess liquidity, what we have in our balance sheet at this moment, 10-11% deposit growth will comfortably provide the adequate funding for our credit growth."

The bank also has liquidity in the form of excess statutory liquidity ratio (SLR) to the tune of ₹3.1 lakh crore, which it can tap into to fund its lending.

Setty attributed the accelerated credit growth in Q1 to a low base in the corresponding quarter of the previous year.

RBI proposal to curb NBFC revolving credit rattles markets

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MUMBAI: A Reserve Bank of India (RBI) proposal to ban non-bank financiers from issuing revolving credit products has investors running for cover, with shares of Bajaj Finance Ltd tumbling nearly 6% on Friday.

The banking regulator on Thursday proposed that non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) be allowed to offer only term loans unless they hold a licence to issue credit cards. Under the November 2025 norms, NBFCs require RBI approval and a minimum net owned fund of ₹100 crore to issue credit cards.

RBI defines revolving credit as a credit facility that does not meet the definition of a term loan. A term loan, according to the central bank, refers to credit with a fixed principal amount, disbursed in one or more instalments and to be repaid on a predetermined schedule. That apart, once disbursed, a term loan limit cannot be replenished after repayment of the whole or a part of the principal.

SBI Cards and Payment Services Ltd, the credit card arm of India's largest lender, State Bank of India,

and BOBCARD, a subsidiary of Bank of Baroda, are the only two non-bank credit card issuers in India.

However, many other NBFCs offer revolving credit, and the quantum is unknown, as they do not disclose the assets under management (AUM) for that line of business, said Suresh Ganapathy, managing director and head of financial services at global adviser and investor Macquarie Capital. "At one point in time, Bajaj Finance had quantified that the flexi loan AUM was 30% of overall AUM. This was 6 years ago. Numbers now in our view could be lower in percentage terms," said Ganapathy.

He said the question is whether even supply chain and inventory funding would qualify as revolving credit. "NBFCs can replace this with a term loan, but the nature of certain kinds of customers is to revolve due to their cash flows being unpredictable or for some other reasons. For example, even today, credit card companies in India have customers to the extent of 20% of their loan book who are happy paying 40% interest rate and revolving," said Ganapathy.

The concerns are not limited to



RBI proposes restricting NBFCs to term loans unless they have a credit card licence.

Bajaj Finance. According to estimates by Viral Shah, senior vice-president, equity research, at brokerage house IIFL Capital Services, such loans account for about 20% of Bajaj Finance's standalone AUM. The share is estimated to be in the high single-digits to low double-digits for Tata Capital and less than 1% for Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Co. Shares of Tata Capital were down 3.2%, while those of Cholamandalam Investment were down 3.8% on the NSE.

"In our assessment, this is a feature that is prevalent across product lines for many NBFCs. This can impact new customer acquisition,

growth, and stickiness, especially for NBFCs that have a meaningfully higher exposure to products having this feature," said Shah.

Shah added that fee income and yields could also be impacted for lenders with meaningful exposure, since these products carry higher fees than other products. However, this can potentially be offset by imposing prepayment charges, which are otherwise typically not charged on loans with this feature.

Queries emailed to Bajaj Finance, Tata Capital and Cholamandalam Investment on Friday evening were not immediately answered.

Others see a potential risk to asset quality if such revolving credit products are suddenly withdrawn. Analysts at Sanford C. Bernstein (India) said flexi-loan structures allow customers to draw, repay and redraw funds from a pre-approved credit limit without undergoing fresh underwriting for every utilization.

These products offer considerable repayment flexibility, including, in some cases, the ability to service only interest obligations for extended periods before principal repayment.

INDIGO IN TALKS WITH EMBAER FOR REGIONAL JETS

Bloomberg
feedback@bloomberg.com

InterGlobe Aviation Ltd., the parent company of India's biggest airline Indigo, is in talks with Embraer SA over a possible large regional jet order, according to people familiar with the matter.

Indigo is considering purchasing dozens of Embraer E2 aircraft to replace its fleet of turbo-prop-powered ATRs as well as to bolster capacity, said the people, who asked not to be identified because the information is confidential.

The discussions are at an early stage and there's no guarantee of an order, they said.

A deal, which could be valued at billions of dollars before customary industry discounts are applied, would be the biggest for the Brazilian manufacturer in India and brings it closer to establishing a full aircraft assembly line in the country. Embraer chief executive officer Francisco Gomes Neto has previously said the planemaker needs to win orders for at least 200 of its E175 regional jets before it considers an Indian assembly facility.

Spokespersons for Indigo and Embraer did not immediately respond to an emailed request for comments.

India pledges to protect farmers' interests at BRICS

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NEW DELHI: Trade ministers of BRICS nations under India's chairmanship concluded their meeting in Jaipur on Friday, with New Delhi pledging to safeguard Indian farmers' interests, ensure food and livelihood security, and preserve special and differential treatment for developing nations in the multilateral trading system.

The meeting concluded with a 20-page chair's statement and outcome document, explicitly noting that its "entire" text, including annexes, was agreed upon by all members, and that "the issue which could not reach consensus is not reflected" in the text.

A chair's statement is typically issued when member states lack consensus on a joint declaration.

The document comprised four annexes covering the revitalization of the multilateral trading system, a work plan on the internationalisation of micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), a work plan on BRICS shared understanding on global value chains (GVCs), and BRICS principles to facilitate digitally delivered services across borders. "The meeting gave a decisive push to small business entrepreneurs. Ministers issued the Jaipur Communiqué to study a BRICS Invoice Discounting Mechanism and adopted the



Piyush Goyal, commerce and industry minister.

Guiding Principles for Credit Assessment Frameworks for Export-Oriented MSMEs, so that a firm is judged by its cash flow and not by its assets and collateral," a statement issued by India's commerce and industry ministry said.

Ministers also made progress

toward finalising the strategy for the BRICS Economic Partnership 2030, spanning trade in services, the digital economy, industry, innovation, financial co-operation, and sustainable development. "Ministers agreed to submit the strategy, together with the priorities to the BRICS Leaders for endorsement," the ministry added. BRICS leaders are scheduled to meet on September 12-13, 2026. The trade minister was attended by member nations including Brazil, China, Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Iran, Russia, South Africa, and the United Arab Emirates (UAE).

The session followed a BRICS industry ministers' meeting held in Jaipur on Thursday under the

chairmanship of Union commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal, which focused on advancing industrial growth. Members adopted a joint declaration reaffirming their commitment to practical co-operation under the BRICS Partnership on New Industrial Revolution (Partnership), which was launched in July 2018. Goyal stated that "BRICS countries must leverage their complementary strengths to build resilient industries and highlighted that PartNIR has evolved into the principal mechanism for this collaboration."

The joint declaration was adopted by Brazil, China, Egypt, Ethiopia, India, Indonesia, Iran, Russia, South Africa, and UAE.

RELIEF FOR DABUR AS HC STAYS FSSAI ORDER ON '100% PURE' CLAIMS

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NEW DELHI: In a relief to Dabur India, the Delhi High Court on Friday stayed the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India's (FSSAI) order that prohibited the consumer goods company from selling its products carrying claims such as "100% Pure", "100% Natural" and "100% Purity Guaranteed".

A bench of Justice Amit Mahajan said, prima facie, the food regulator should not have passed the prohibitory order without first giving Dabur an opportunity to be heard.

Justice Mahajan issued Ex-parte on Dabur's petition challenging the FSSAI's 3 August order and directed the regulator to file its response within 15 days. The interim stay on the order was in effect until the next date of hearing on 24 August.

"This court is of the opinion that the prohibitory order of such nature ought not to have been passed without affording an opportunity of holding. Till the next stage, the effect of the impugned order is stayed," the court said.

The FSSAI had directed Dabur to stop selling products with the impugned claims, saying such statements could not be scientifically verified and were likely to mislead consumers by creating the impression that the products were superior to competing brands. The order covered several products, including honey, ghee, sesame oil, coconut water and coconut milk.

Appearing for Dabur, senior advocate Sandeep Sethi argued that the regulator had exceeded its statutory powers by issuing what was effectively a prohibitory order without following due process.

He contended the order had been passed without giving the company a show-cause notice or an opportunity of a hearing, in violation of the principles of natural justice.

Appearing for FSSAI, counsel Ashish Dixit said the issue concerning Dabur's "100%" claims is already pending before the Delhi High Court in a separate petition relating to Real Fruit juice, where interim protection has been granted.

Oil cos say E20 petrol meets quality norms

Press Trust of India
feedback@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: State-run oil marketing companies (OMCs) said on Friday that additional nationwide testing of E20 petrol found no evidence to support claims of high moisture or chloride contamination, with fuel quality remaining within prescribed limits across the supply chain.

The intensified testing followed recent media reports alleging the presence of moisture and chloride in E20 (20 per cent ethanol blended petrol).

Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd in a joint statement said the exercise covered the entire supply chain and reaffirmed that fuel quality remained "consistently well within prescribed limits." "Contrary to certain assertions being made, there is no evidence of any alarm on account of fuel contamination validated

by extensive and scientifically designed tests," the companies said.

The three OMCs said the government has prescribed stringent chloride specifications for ethanol used in petrol blending and has put in place high-frequency monitoring at refineries, distilleries, depots, terminals and retail outlets to ensure compliance.

The companies said they have also strengthened quality surveillance by conducting water-ingress and density tests 8-12 times a day at every retail outlet, deploying mobile fuel quality testing laboratories and independently validating results through fuel laboratories.

More than 100 additional petrol samples collected from refineries showed chloride levels at or below 1 part per million (ppm), while ethanol samples from 80 distilleries tested over the past 10 days recorded chloride content below 3 ppm, OMCs said.

HINDALCO PROFIT JUMPS 75% IN JUNE QUARTER

Bloomberg
feedback@hindustantimes.com

Hindalco Industries Ltd's first-quarter profit jumped 75%, beating estimates as supply disruptions from the Middle East war drove metal prices higher.

Net income in the three months through June rose to ₹7,000 crore (\$736 million), from ₹4,000 crore a year earlier, according to a filing to stock exchanges. That beat ₹5,810 crore average of analyst estimates compiled by Bloomberg. The group's revenue rose 32% to ₹84,835 crore.

Shares extended gains after the earnings, closing up 3.2% to touch a two-month peak.

Average benchmark aluminium prices on London Metal Exchange were up 43% higher year-on-year in the June quarter, while copper was up 4%. Contribution from the company's US unit Novelis also surged after the aluminium products maker's net income for the quarter rose 71% to \$164 million, despite constrained shipments.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★

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{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW

SATURDAY	SUNDAY	MONDAY
Generally cloudy sky with light rain	Generally cloudy sky with light rain or drizzle	Generally cloudy sky with light rain
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Cautious India frustrated by Sri Lanka Cricket XI on opening day

Fifties from openers saw the hosts finish the opening day of the three-day warm-up match on 363/8

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MUMBAI: There was little to dislike about India's first day of preparation for the Test series against Sri Lanka, except perhaps the preparation itself. Sri Lanka XI finished the opening day of the three-day warm-up match on 363/8 from 90 overs, spending much of Friday batting with a comfort that India would probably have preferred not to provide.

On a placid Nondescripts Cricket Club pitch, the hosts were allowed to settle, build partnerships and test the patience of an Indian attack that was playing its first competitive cricket at this level since the home series against South Africa in November 2025.

India's caution was understandable. Shubman Gill, the Test captain, had already been ruled out after injuring his right ring finger during practice, with the BCCI medical team monitoring the injury ahead of the first Test. KL Rahul stepped up, drawing all the more attention to the decisions taken throughout the day. These games are supposed to expose rust, test combinations and provide information about conditions and players. By the end of Day 1, India may have wondered whether they had extracted enough of that information.

The first session belonged decisively to Sri Lanka XI, breezing their way to 180 in 29 overs. Although India's bowlers were not particularly wayward, there was little sense of sustained pressure. Nishan Fernando made 66 from 65 balls with 11 fours and a six, before a bizarre mix-up finally ended the opening partnership with Ravindra Rasanthan. Instead, Rasanthan and Pasindu Sooriyabandara rebuilt. Rasanthan, 43, was the most useful of the day. He repeatedly used his feet against the spinners, unshackled more by India's



Indian players during Day 1 of the warm-up match against Sri Lanka Cricket XI at the NCC Ground in Colombo on Friday.

reluctance to attack with cutters around the bat.

Sooriyabandara made 35 before Jadeja had him beaten by pace and trajectory in the 41st over. He rocked back to pull a delivery that was not short enough, and the ball skidded through to hit the stumps. At tea Sri Lanka XI were 246/4. Four more wickets fell in the final 30 overs, but even that late cluster did not entirely change the complexion of the day.

India's spinners eventually accounted for six wickets between them. Suthar was the standout, finishing with 2/33 from 13 overs. His best wicket was Ravindra, who had been stepping down the pitch successfully for much of his innings before

Suthar finally beat him with flight and dip. Rasantha advanced again, failed to reach the pitch and skewed a catch to deepish mid-off.

That was precisely the sort of wicket that demonstrated why warm-up matches matter. Suthar had started cautiously but settled into a disciplined length, and his 2.53 economy rate was the best among India's bowlers. Kuldeep Yadav also claimed two wickets, dismissing Alan Wickramasinghe and Anjala Bandara. Wickramasinghe top-edged a sweep after Kuldeep shortened his length and induced a little extra bounce. Bandara then misjudged one that skidded on and was trapped LBW.

Ravindra Jadeja also took two, including Ramesh Mendis, who edged a full delivery outside off to first slip, where Devdutt Padikal took a fine low catch. Sri Lanka captain Sonal Dinusha then became Suthar's second victim, bow for 52 after missing another sweep against a full delivery that stayed low.

Yet India's bowling figures also tell another story. Mohammed Siraj and Prashidhi Krishna combined for 20 overs and went for 76 without a wicket. Siraj was economical enough, conceding 44 from 13, but neither he nor Krishna appeared to be threatening consistently. Ganesan Babu was perhaps the most intriguing sight among India's newer seamers. He bowled 12 overs for 49 and picked

up Pavan Rathnayake with a short-ball plan that worked. Rathnayake swivelled at a shoulder-high bounce and picked out the fielder at deep backward square leg. Brar's pace and bounce was beguiling on a flat surface. But the fact that he bowled only 12 overs, while Kuldeep was given 18, underlined India's conservative approach to workload and experimentation.

Sarathin Jain had an equally informative but less successful outing, conceding 54 in 11 overs. He started bowling from round the wicket, pushing the ball through and getting punished immediately. But it improved when he came over the wicket and looked to give the ball more loopy.

Overall, the field placements rarely suggested India were trying to force the issue. There were periods when Sri Lanka's batters could simply settle into their shots, particularly against the new-ball attack.

None of this should be over interpreted. It's a warm-up, not a Test, and India had obvious reasons to avoid unnecessary risk after Gill's injury. But warm-ups exist precisely because the consequences are supposed to be limited. They are the safest place to

be bold, to attack with close catchers, test rookie bowlers for longer spells, try unusual field settings and discover what works before the real contest begins. India did some of that on Friday, but clearly not enough of it.



R Praggnanandhaa won the St. Louis Rapid and Blitz.

'Everything looks smooth but that wasn't the case'

HT Correspondent
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Praggnanandhaa is snapping up interviews after winning the St. Louis Rapid & Blitz. Within earshot is his older sister, Vaishali, the Rameshbabu family's other Grandmaster and a contender in next year's Women's World Championship.

Usually, their mother, Nagalakshmi, accompanies Praggnanandhaa to tournaments. This time with Nagalakshmi unable to travel, Vaishali arrived a week early ahead of the Cairns Cup, the strongest invitational women's tournament in the world, which begins in St. Louis on Saturday.

Asked how his sister's presence helped, Praggnanandhaa grins and slips into familiar sibling banter. "Maybe we should kick her out before I answer." Then comes the earnest reply. "I usually have my mother here. But this time she had some work, so my sister accompanied me. It's good to have someone who understands chess, like when you make some mistakes you can go back... basically it's a lot easier to talk about the game. So, it's great to have her." He offered.

The Indian GM turned in a classy performance, leading from start to finish, to win the event with a round to spare. It included managing to hold a pawn-down endgame against World Championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov in the penultimate round. It was a fairly stacked field with three of the world's top 5 players — Fabiano Caruana, Sindarov and Vincent Keymer, in it.

The tournament win saw Prag climb to second in the Grand Chess Tour standings, behind Caruana. He'll be staying overnight in the Missouri city to play the Sinquefeld Cup which will have nine rounds of classical chess, starting next week, the final event before the Grand Chess Tour finals. "When you see the score, everything looks smooth but it wasn't the case," Praggnanandhaa told St. Louis Chess Club. "It was crazy. Kudos to Javokhir, he played the fight till the end."

Heading into the final day of the event with Sindarov snapping at his heels, Praggnanandhaa's fate to sell was not done anything stupid. He began the final day of Blitz on a wobbly note. Playing with Black, Prag turned down a draw against Awonder Liang

though he had neither a perpetual check nor a checkmate, and ended up losing. He defeated Anish Giri with a queenside breakthrough, Leinier Domínguez on time and his pawn-down game against Sindarov which ended in a draw, was enough to see him through to the title. "Sometimes, it's not enough to play well. You need to be lucky too," rued Sindarov, who ended 1.5 points behind Praggnanandhaa. The Uzbek will play defending world champion Gukesh for the world title later this year.

For Praggnanandhaa, it's been quite the arc. In 2024, he finished dead last in the St. Louis Rapid and Blitz. Two years later, he's taking home a \$50,000 cheque and a large silver trophy for first place in the same tournament. "It's a massive improvement." "Last year, I was in a position where I had to perform in Sinquefeld Cup. This time, because of Rapid and Blitz, I got good scores. I'm happy I managed to improve in that area and my Rapid and Blitz is getting better."

He has enjoyed an impressive run across formats this year. In June, he won Norway Chess, the classical event that included two victories over world No.1 Magnus Carlsen. Now, he has topped both the rapid and blitz sections in St. Louis.

He started the year on a slightly despondent note, with an underwhelming performance at the Candidates in Cyprus. However, Vaishali, went on to win the Women's Candidates, which took place at the same time. She became only the second Indian woman after Koneru Humpy to qualify for the match. Her victory, to some extent, helped ease his disappointment, as he accompanied her to her titillation events. Back in 2012, they set out on their first international trip together, for the Asian Youth Championship in Hikkadawa, Sri Lanka. Back then, the biggest challenge was shoring travel funds for both the siblings and their mother, Nagalakshmi. They both returned champions — Vaishali, a bronze medalist, and Praggnanandhaa, winning the U-8.

Nearly 15 years later, the scene has changed but the script remains the same. The siblings are still travelling together, still leaning on each other — only now, the trophies in their carry-on luggage are bigger.

After a quiet CWG in the pool, SFI mulls 'reinventing' training systems

Rutvik Mehta
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MUMBAI: Even in a Commonwealth Games of strapped sports and shoestring budgets, Glasgow 2026 featured the largest swimming programme of any edition. Truncated or full-fledged, the pool still rewards a huge chunk of medals at the CWG (of toppers Australia's 171 medals and 70 gold, swimmers contributed 76 and 37).

The pool remains India's major area for improvement for a bigger push in multi-sport events. The country's able-bodied swimmers were by no means expected to challenge for medals at Glasgow. However, their below-par performances convinced the national federation to look at 'reinventing the training system' in the hope of Indian swimmers being more competitive in the 2030 Commonwealth Games.

At the 2022 CWG, Indians qualified for the final from heats in four events, with Srihari Nataraj also making a national record apart from making two finals. There was no such individual brilliance in Glasgow, with only Sajjan Prakash (200m butterfly) and the 4x200m men's freestyle relay team advancing from the heats to the final (Aryan Nehra's 800m and 1,500m freestyle events did not have a heat). Timing-wise too, most swimmers had done better. Sajjan, 32, finished last in the 200m butterfly final with a timing of 1:58.05. He had clocked 1:57.10 in March in Singapore. Nataraj, 25, clocked 25.29 in the semi-final of 50m backstroke, his primary event in which his personal best is 25.18. Fresh off going sub-8 in June, Nehra, 22, clocked 8:07.26 in 800m freestyle. "The CWG was not a good outcome. It could have been better," said Monal Chokshi, general secretary of Swimming Federation of India

India's poor show in the pool

Most of the country's top swimmers had below-par timings at the 2026 CWG, and will hope to turn up a lot better at the Asian Games.

		SAJJAN PRAKASH		SRIHARI NATARAJ		ARYAN NEHRA	
		200M BUTTERFLY	50M BUTTERFLY	200M FREESTYLE	50M BACKSTROKE	100M BACKSTROKE	800M FREESTYLE
		24.94	28.11	20.11	11.11	12.11	8.11
		1:58.05	24.94	1:51.99	25.29	55.52	8:07.26
		15:36.25	15:36.25	15:36.25	15:36.25	15:36.25	4:00.26
		1:56.38	24.76	1:49.73	25.18	53.77	7:59.36
		15:14.88	15:14.88	15:14.88	15:14.88	15:14.88	3:52.55

(SFI). The calendar, however, didn't help. With the Nationals in June — from where a majority qualified for CWG and Asian Games — the CWG in July-August and Asian Games in September-October, the swimmers could not taper for CWG. Most also prioritised Asian Games over CWG. "More importance was given to the Asian Games. That was an individual decision that some swimmers took," said Dronacharya awardee Nihar Ameen, the contingent's coach. "We're hoping for a better performance at the Asian Games, where the swimmers will be more prepared, rested, and will perform better in terms of at least bringing national records and doing

better than CWG." The likes of Nehra and Rishabh Das are training abroad, while Srihari now prefers a high-intensity, low-volume programme, said Ameen. A 45-day training methodology needs to be revisited. Performances at the top level are eluding us so far. For that, foreign expertise and camps have to be more frequent. We need that expertise to train all potential candidates as an India squad, and not have these isolated training centres where people are doing their fall into that framework. Because otherwise, a four-year window is still short, but if you're looking at 2032 and 2036, the same old same old is clearly not going to work."

The SFI has had 'serious conversations' with the sports ministry and Sports Authority of India to work towards creating a proper training centre. For the next four years, with the Ahmedabad focus as 'priority No.1,' said Chokshi, the CWG will have to be on grooming the next batch in the 17-21 age group and promising actual bodily harm. "If the emerging pack of junior swimmers are handled right, they will be in good shape in four years time," said Ameen.

"That's the only way forward in the next cycle," said Chokshi. "And we'll have to get together on what is really required. Then the swimmers would have to fall into that framework. Because otherwise, a four-year window is still short, but if you're looking at 2032 and 2036, the same old same old is clearly not going to work."

ENGLAND STRIKER TONEY CHARGED WITH ASSAULT

LONDON: England striker Ivan Toney has been charged with assault at a Soho nightclub, London's Metropolitan Police said on Friday, with the 30-year-old due in court next month. The charge relates to an assault that allegedly took place on December 6 last year at a nightclub on Wardour Street. "Ivan Toney, 30, of Northampton, was charged on Thursday, 31 July with assault causing actual bodily harm," the police stated. "He will appear at Westminster Magistrates' Court on 24 September."

Ashmita, Rakshitha book semis showdown in Korea

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ASAN: Indian shuttlers Ashmita Chaitali and Rakshitha Ramraj will square off in the women's singles semi-finals of the \$250,000 Korea Masters after registering hard-fought wins in their respective quarter-finals here on Friday.

World No. 50 Ashmita produced the biggest upset of the tournament so far, shocking top seed and World No. 22 Hina Akechi to Japan 2-0, 21-15, 21-19 in a gripping quarter-final at the Asan Yit Sun-sin Gymnasium.

The victory also helped the Indian advance a defeat in their only previous meeting at the Malaysia Super 100 last year. Rakshitha, meanwhile, came back from a game down to upset third seed and compatriot Tanvi Sharma 18-21, 21-19, in a contest that lasted over an hour. It was her fourth win over Tanvi, who had claimed her maiden BWI World Tour title at Taipei Open last week.

However, India's Krishna Prasad Ganga and Pruthvi Krishnamurthy Roy crashed out



Ashmita Chaitali.

after 17-15 and 18-16. She also earned a game point at 20-19 after Hina found the net but failed to convert it. Hina then rallied to a 2-1 lead and carrying an 11-9 advantage into the interval. She stretched it to 18-11 before Hina mounted a spirited comeback, winning six consecutive points to narrow the gap to 17-18. Ashmita, however, held her nerve in the closing stages to seal a memorable victory.

Rakshitha raced to a 15-8 lead in the opening game before Tanvi mounted a remarkable comeback, reeling off eight of the next nine points to move from 8-13 to 16-14 before closing out the game.



India skipper Harmanpreet Singh.

'India has ability to upset anyone'

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LUCKNOW: As India heads into the hockey World Cup next week aiming for a podium finish after a 51-year gap, chief selector RP Singh is confident the team have the balance, temperament, and tactical flexibility to compete for medals.

The selectors have prioritised players who fit the team's evolving style. This emphasis reflects a broader shift in world hockey toward multi-functional athletes, including forwards who press and track back, midfielders who can both break lines and recycle possession, and defenders who initiate play rather than simply clear the ball. "Now, it's everybody's game and modern defensive responsibilities extend well into the opponent's half, meaning selection now favours athletes comfortable with both ball progression and defensive duties," Singh said on Friday.

India's recent podium finishes, including back-to-back medals at the Olympics, indicate a maturing system rather than one-off successes.

A central pillar of Singh's optimism is the blend of experienced leaders and promising youngsters in the squad. "We are a balanced side and barring a few youngsters, others have enough experience of tackling any rival in the world. Now, veterans supply composure, institutional knowledge and the ability to manage high-pressure moments; emerg-

ing players contribute energy, unpredictability and adaptability," he said. "If players play their natural game within the structure the coaches have shaped, India should be in contention for a medal."

He also highlighted that many of the younger athletes have already demonstrated their readiness during continental fixtures and invitational tournaments. "The importance of grooming a second layer of talent now so the team remains competitive through Olympic cycles — specifically eyeing continuity toward 2028 while acknowledging inevitable retirements and role changes," he said. "Our juniors too have been doing wonders and I am sure that many of them will make it to the squad for the 2028 Olympics."

He also believes India is better prepared than in past cycles. "The European opponents or Australia can beat anyone at any time, but I feel India has the ability to do the same. I have already told the squad that they should treat every pool match like a semi-final. Early wins can create momentum that carries a team deep into the knockout rounds," he said. "I am also confident about a good show by our women's team as they too are studied with a blend of young and experienced players. They have already proved their worth by showing well in the Asian Champions Trophy in 2016, 2022 and even in 2024, and the FIH Nations Cup twice in 2022 and 2026."

Bridging gap to the top needs turning grassroots numbers into an engineered system: Gopichand

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NEW DELHI: As Indian shuttlers prepare for the BWF World Championships starting August 17, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty once again stand as the country's best bet for glory. But behind their trailblazing achievements lies a critical question facing Indian badminton: what comes after the ace pair?

Building a sustainable supply chain of world-class doubles pairs remains one of the most pressing challenges for Indian badminton. Chief national coach Pullela Gopichand believes that securing the future of Indian doubles requires early talent specialisation, central coordination, and a comprehensive overhaul of the national coaching framework.

For decades, Indian badminton has operated under a heavy singles-centric system. Young shuttlers overwhelmingly aspire to follow in the footsteps of singles greats like Saina Nehwal or PV Sindhu, leaving doubles as a secondary alternative. "To create a supply chain of elite doubles pairs, Gopichand emphasises that players and coaches must make deliberate, early interventions rather than waiting for players to fall back on doubles later in their careers. "Younger age specialisations are important. It is also important that people pick doubles as a sport. Very rarely do we have a decent singles player pick doubles if he is good at that. Not very often do you see that switch and that is an important switch to happen," says the former All England champion.

The 52-year-old adds that several of India's biggest success stories in both singles and doubles stemmed from decisive, top-



Ace Indian doubles pair Satwiksairaj Rankireddy (L) and Chirag Shetty.

down coaching calls rather than individual player preferences.

"For example, Satwik has been with me for the last 14 years. When Satwik came up, I said no singles, you have to play doubles. Or say, (Kidambi) Srikanth was playing mixed doubles and I said, no, you have to play singles," said Gopichand. "Gayatri (Gopichand) was selected for the (2018) Asian Games in singles. And then after that I said, no, you are better off playing doubles. So sometimes the conscious choice to move players from singles to doubles is an important one."

The Dronacharya awardee recalls a similar intervention with Ashwini Ponnappa in 2006 when she was playing singles, saying that "to make that shift,

somebody come up and say that confidently, that's an important thing."

A major factor in changing player attitudes is the presence of role models. While youngsters idolise stars like Saina and Sindhu, the unprecedented success of Satwik-Chirag has proven that doubles offers equal avenues for acclaim.

"Somehow in our country, singles still seems to be a priority. Sometimes good talent doesn't come which could be exceptional, good talent for singles but exceptional talent for doubles," adds Gopichand. "We need influences like this and results from Satwik-Chirag. I don't want to end up saying I want to become like Sindhu or Lakshya (Sen) or Srikanth, but

you would also want to be like Satwik-Chirag. That's an important shift."

Beyond mindset, structural fragmentation poses a formidable challenge. Over the past five years, India's badminton footprint has expanded dramatically from "4-5 prominent academies to over 500, housing roughly 5,000 independent players". While this boom reflects unprecedented grassroots interest, it creates logjams when trying to pair compatible players across different regions and private setups. "We are very democratic in that setup. When you come to doubles, that compounds the problem because how do you manage this?" asks Gopichand.

Forming elite doubles combinations requires bringing

together complementary skill sets that may not exist within a single academy or state.

"The second thing is to find the best players. If a good player from Haryana has to play with a good player from Kerala, how do you mix both of them and make them play as a combination? Chirag was playing with MR Arjun and Satwik was playing with Krishna Prasad. Since both of them were training with me, I could actually instrument that (change), but if that was not the case and if they were not part of the national camp then we can't actually do that," said Gopichand.

This dynamic underscores where the broader system urgently requires attention. Junior participation has skyrocketed, with recent U-15 and U-17 national tournaments drawing over 4,200 entries alongside massive tournaments in U-11 and U-13 divisions. However, the administrative and technical infrastructure has been overwhelmed by the sheer volume. "We are terribly understaffed in coaches and terribly understaffed in systems. And our tournament structure needs to be upgraded very frequently because the numbers are getting higher every year," Gopichand admits.

Asked to identify the immediate priorities for Indian badminton, he mentioned two essential elements. "Of all the things which are important, if I were to pick the important things, I would say coaching is an important aspect. Systems engineering would be another. How do you get the best players to train together in a systematic format?"

While India's prospect at the Worlds looks competitive, the country's long-term standing in world badminton hinges on structural reform. Bridging the gap to the world's elite requires turning grassroots numbers into an engineered system, one that identifies doubles talent early, connects top players across academy lines and provides the coaching calibre required to form the next Satwik-Chirag.

DPL games called off due to rain

NEW DELHI: Both Delhi Premier League games were abandoned without a ball being bowled on Friday due to heavy rain. The afternoon match between East Delhi Riders and West Delhi Lions was abandoned, as was the second game in the evening between Outer Delhi Warriors, North Delhi Strikers.

Ashfaq breaks U-20 NR in 400m

EUGENE: Mohammed Ashfaq broke the U-20 national record to qualify for the men's 400m semi-finals while Amanat Kamboj ended sixth in women's discus throw with a personal best effort on Day 2 of the World Athletics U20 Championships here. The 19-year-old Ashfaq clocked 45.81 seconds.

Head wins Allan Border medal

BREKIDANE: Travis Head was on Friday crowned Australia's leading male cricketer, winning the Allan Border Medal for a consecutive year. At a function held here to celebrate the 2025-26 season for Australia's men's teams, Head claimed top honours while Mitchell Starc was named Shane Warne Men's Test Player of the Year, Mitchell Marsh claimed Men's ODI Player of the Year and Tim David the Men's T20I Player of the Year.

Titi bags silver in Jr Asian lifting

NOIDA: Titi Majhi won silver in women's 45kg as India made an impressive start on Day 1 of the Asian Youth & Junior Weightlifting Championships in Tashkent.

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